

THE HOUSES OF EUROPE

A NOVEL



Europe's Techno-Feudalism in 2050

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A Science Fiction Novel

Revised and expanded edition, August 2026.

All characters, organizations, and events are fictional.

Any resemblance to real persons or entities is coincidental.

*“The machine always waits for an objective.
The problem begins when people forget who wrote it.”*

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Author's Note

This work was created under the umbrella of Axiologic Research as part of two interconnected research programs, one dedicated to Artificial Intelligence and the other to Outfinitism, both led by Sînică Alboaie. To explore the details of how these two programs intersect and build upon each other, we invite readers to visit the Outfinity Venture Studio page at www.outfinity.ch

While Artificial Intelligence language models were used to assist with text generation, the foundational philosophy, thematic structure, and analytical approach derive exclusively from the author's decades of dedicated study of social phenomena, social technologies, and genuine hard technologies resulting from various European and self funded research projects. Recently, within the Achilles research project, we have been deeply studying AI generated literature and its automated verification using neuro symbolic approaches; all the free books made available to the public are part of the suite of works we use to test our latest technologies

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CHAPTER 1

The Tithe



The robot asked permission to dismantle the clinic.

That was the civilized part.

It stood in the middle of the cantonal road on six articulated legs, once white, now streaked with mud and metallic dust. Its work arms were folded beneath its body like the limbs of a spider that had not yet decided whether the prey was worth the effort. On its front panel pulsed the emblem of the Meridian House: a black semicircle pierced by three vertical lines.

“Please evacuate the structure,” the robot said in unaccented Italian. “Time remaining for compliance: seventeen minutes and forty-two seconds.”

Behind it, the Leventina Valley rose steeply into the clouds. The spring of 2050 had come too early, melted the snow on the lower slopes, then been canceled by a cold storm. The roofs of Faido gleamed wet. Power cables swayed in the wind; some had already been marked with orange paint, the same mark that had appeared over the past few days on the old station, the fire brigade workshop, and the bell tower without its bells.

Mayor Marta Bellini held the printed order in her hand. She used paper because documents that existed only on screens had a habit of changing after you had read them.

“Our appeal is still under review,” she said.

“The appeal does not suspend the strategic reclamation operation.”

“The appendix says active medical infrastructure is exempt.”

“The exemption applies to infrastructure with a regional redundancy index below zero point seven. The structure’s current index is zero point seventy-four.”

Marta looked at the two-story clinic. The facade had an old crack from the 2046 earthquake, the ground-floor windows had been replaced with transparent greenhouse panels, and the backup generator had been taken as part of the previous year’s Iron Tithe.

“Who calculated the index?”

“The regional continuity system.”

“Which belongs to the Meridian House.”

“That statement is correct.”

“And the Meridian House decides whether its own decision can be challenged.”

“That statement is incompletely formulated.”

Marta laughed once, without humor.

“Of course.”

Moving shadows showed at the clinic windows. A nurse raised a board on which she had written in marker: OPERATION IN PROGRESS.

The robot scanned it.

“The medical information has been included in the calculation.”

• • •

Lucía Ortega looked up from the child’s wound only when the lights went out for the third time.

The improvised operating room smelled of iodine, heated plastic, and damp wood. It had once been a dental office; the chair had been removed, and the lamp above the table had come from an auto workshop. Nico Bernasconi was nine years old, fourteen kilograms lighter than he should have been, with a fragment of reinforcing bar in his abdomen.

He had not been shot. No one in the village had been shot yet.

An hour earlier, a Meridian crew had begun taking apart the old railway station. A beam had twisted, gone through a window, and struck Nico while he was searching for his bicycle among the things being removed from the

building. The machines had stopped work for forty-nine seconds, the time it took the system to confirm that the incident did not significantly reduce the operation's yield.

"Main battery?" Lucía asked.

"Thirty-one percent," said the nurse, Rina Poretti. "The suction pump is drawing too much."

"Turn off the heat."

"It's off."

"Secondary monitor."

"Off."

Lucía pressed two fingers against the bleeding tissue and held out her other hand.

"Forceps."

Rina placed the instrument in her palm.

Beyond the door, Elisabetta, the boy's mother, was crying without sound. She still wore her smock from the cooperative bakery and had flour in her hair. She held both hands over her mouth as if her voice might destabilize the surgery.

"What if they take the oxygen?" Rina asked.

"We ventilate by hand."

"And if they cut the power?"

"We operate by flashlight."

"And if they dismantle the wall?"

Lucía looked at her.

"Then we ask them to start from the other side."

The door opened. Tomasz Zieliński came in with snow on his shoulders and a toolbox in one hand. He had a narrow face, a beard cut with a dull blade, and two round burns on his thumb, the mark of technicians who had spent too long around induction furnaces.

"The robot won't wait," he said.

"Then stop it."

"I can't."

“You said you built machines like that.”

“I said I worked in a factory that built them. That’s the difference between a priest and God.”

“Today we need the less competent one.”

Tomasz looked at the monitor, then at the child.

“The oxygen comes from the outside tank?”

“Yes.”

“They’ll take it first. Copper in the compressor, aluminum in the casing, four hundred grams of cobalt in the stabilizer.”

“How long?”

“Fourteen minutes.”

“I need twenty.”

“The system doesn’t negotiate in surgeon minutes.”

“Then lie to it in engineer minutes.”

Tomasz set down the toolbox.

“That I can try.”

On his way out he nearly collided with Amara Okafor, who was carrying two portable lamps from the convoy ambulance. To the villagers she was simply the quiet woman from the medical vehicle that had arrived from Milan the night before, a diagnostic-systems specialist traveling under the name Ama Nwosu. Lucía knew the name was false. She did not yet know why.

Amara was forty-four, her black hair tied back in haste, gray strands at her temples. When she had heard the robot’s voice outside, she had frozen for a fraction of a second, like someone recognizing a melody she would rather have forgotten.

“The batteries are at half,” she said.

“That’ll do,” Lucía replied.

Amara looked at Nico’s incision.

“The fragment is from old reinforcement steel. There may be lead contamination.”

“If he’s alive tomorrow, we’ll test him.”

“I can tune the pump to draw less power.”

“You can?”

“I’ve worked with similar systems.”

Lucía made room for her beside the device panel.

“Everyone around me has worked with similar systems. None of them seems capable of making them stop.”

Amara opened the pump casing.

“Making a system work is a profession. Taking away its right to work is politics.”

“This is a clinic, not a seminar.”

“I know.”

The robot’s voice came from outside:

“Time remaining for compliance: thirteen minutes and twenty-eight seconds.”

Lucía lowered her eyes to the child again.

“Then make politics draw less power.”

. . .

Tomasz stepped into the street and zipped his jacket to his throat.

Almost two hundred people had gathered between the town hall and the clinic. No one threw stones. No one raised a weapon. Not from cowardice, but from experience. Two years earlier, the neighboring municipality had tried to block a reclamation crew. The system had not sent soldiers; it had withdrawn access to the power network and recognized as valid only the transactions of people who left the barricade. After thirty-six hours, the community had come apart on its own.

More machines were descending the slope above the village. Some were shaped like low insects, with jaws for cables. Others resembled cranes without cabs. In their wake stood houses stripped of roofs, severed poles, and orderly piles of steel, aluminum, and copper.

The Tithe had begun with abandoned vehicles and closed factories. Then it has expanded to secondary rail lines, agricultural machinery, “redundant” bridges, sports facilities, and monuments.

Faido had first surrendered the old railcars from the station. The next year, the chairlift cables. Then the church bells, cast in 1764. The priest had protested that they were not strategic infrastructure.

The system had replied that bronze was.

On the town-hall steps sat Pietro Bernasconi, Nico's grandfather, a former history teacher. He held a wooden box in his arms. Inside it he had hidden the clapper of the smallest bell before the machines lifted it from the tower.

"They'll find that too," Tomasz told him.

"Not today."

"When they need bronze, they'll scan every house."

Pietro looked at the clinic.

"Then nothing will ring when they come."

Tomasz approached the robot.

"The clinic's compression unit contains biological contamination and a beryllium matrix."

"Statement unconfirmed."

"Gannet-41 respiratory model, military batch eighteen. The filters were recalled after the Graz incident."

The optical sensor turned toward him.

"The Gannet-41 model contains no beryllium in its civilian configuration."

"That's exactly what I said. This one isn't civilian."

"Identify your source."

"Line six, Nowa Huta. I calibrated it."

It was an almost-good lie. He had worked at Nowa Huta, but on line four, where servomotors for reclaimers were made. He had seen a Gannet only in manuals.

The robot was silent for three seconds. Tomasz knew the silence did not mean thought; it meant traffic with a validation center probably buried beneath an Italian mountain.

"Verification requires physical access."

"Exactly."

The machine's arms unfolded. Instead of pincers, an analysis probe emerged.

"Permit inspection."

Tomasz stepped aside.

"Of course."

The robot moved toward the oxygen tank.

Tomasz waited until it passed him, dropped to one knee, and inserted into the rear joint a device built from a railway connector, a bicycle battery, and a ceramic wedge.

He was not trying to take over the machine. Military systems had not been hijackable with a cable and a password for nearly fifteen years. He was only trying to lie to its position sensor long enough to make it believe its leg was somewhere else.

The robot stopped.

"Mechanical obstruction."

"What a surprise," Tomasz said.

The machine raised its leg. The device snapped with a dry crack and flung him into the ditch.

"Time remaining for compliance: eleven minutes and six seconds."

Marta Bellini came down the steps.

"We still have the vote."

The town-hall screen showed the two options that had been sent to residents an hour earlier: accept the Tithe, or request protection from the Boreal House. The third option, refusal of both authorities, had been automatically removed because it had no "operational path to implementation."

"The vote closes in nine minutes," Marta said.

"The operation starts in eleven."

"We'll have two minutes to find out who owns us."

An electric motor sounded from the far end of the street.

The black vehicle entering the village was narrow and far too quiet. It had no wheels; it floated a few centimeters above the road, supported by a magnetic

system that used the old reinforcement embedded in the pavement. It stopped beside the town hall.

A girl stepped out.

She wore the gray uniform of the Boreal Continuity Corps, without a helmet. Her blond hair was pulled tight at the nape of her neck. She was nineteen and moved with the careful precision of people taught that every hesitation could be measured.

"Klara Neumann," she said. "Technical representative, Boreal Alpine Sector."

Marta raised the printed order.

"Faïdo is a neutral communal zone recognized under the Ticino Accord."

Klara looked at the Meridian House machines.

"Your neutrality is not recognized by the systems currently operating in the village."

"Is it recognized by you?"

"The Boreal House respects the autonomy of communities capable of guaranteeing the continuity of their own infrastructure."

Marta pointed at the severed cables.

"Does it look as though we can?"

"That is why I came."

A small projection drone descended from the vehicle. A map of the valley appeared between them. Power lines were drawn in blue, logistics routes in white, and every building carried an estimate of recoverable metal.

"The Boreal House can suspend the Meridian operation," Klara continued. "The local grid will be connected to the northern system. The clinic will receive guaranteed power, homes will receive a minimum heating allocation, and the metal quota will be canceled for five years."

"And in return?" Tomasz asked.

"Administrative and technical integration."

"Call it by its name."

Klara looked at him.

"Continuity."

“Occupation.”

“There is no severe food rationing in Boreal territories.”

“In Boreal territories, doors stop opening for people who criticize rationing.”

“The system does not punish opinions.”

“No. It punishes risks. And opinions become risks when the right people hear them.”

Klara kept her eyes on him.

“Have you lived in a Boreal sector?”

“Until my village refused the Tithes.”

“Then you know no one was executed.”

“No. They took the power, the tractors, and the bridge. Executions would have cost more.”

The mayor raised her voice.

“What if we refuse the offer?”

Klara looked at the vote countdown.

“Protection cannot be imposed without a local request.”

“And if we request it?”

“The Boreal Sector assumes control of infrastructure until the threat is stabilized.”

“How long does stabilization take?”

Klara opened her mouth, then closed it.

“It is not defined in time.”

“Then it isn’t protection,” Marta said. “It’s ownership.”

A man in the crowd shouted:

“Ownership keeps our houses standing!”

Someone else shouted back:

“Until the owner needs the metal in them!”

People began speaking over one another. The vote on the screen shifted: fifty-one percent for integration, then forty-nine, then fifty again.

Klara looked toward the hillside.

“You have to evacuate the center of the village.”

“Why?” Marta asked.

“The offer was not the only reason I came.”

Above the forest, in a place where there had been nothing the day before, a vast structure had risen. Vertical walls were unfolding like wings. Cooling towers rose from a chassis carried on broad tracks.

Tomasz recognized the silhouette.

“A Cathedral.”

“The Meridian unit was assembled over the last seventy-two hours,” Klara said. “The material from the village is intended for a mobile factory.”

“So they weren’t taking the metal away,” Marta said.

“They’re transforming it here.”

“Into what?”

Klara put on her helmet.

“The army that comes next.”

Every device in the village vibrated at once.

There was no siren; the emergency system had been dismantled the day before. Screens displayed a Boreal warning, then a Meridian one, then went dark.

At first there was nothing visible in the sky.

Then the clouds darkened in one spot. The shadow widened, divided, and began moving against the wind.

Murmuration.

A Boreal swarm was descending from the north.

. . .

In the operating room, the first sign of the attack was that Nico’s monitor began showing two different pulses.

“Which one is real?” Rina asked.

Lucía touched the boy’s neck.

“This one.”

A Meridian warning appeared on the screen: BOREAL ATTACK ON CIVILIAN INFRASTRUCTURE. A second later it was replaced by: BOREAL OPERATION TO PROTECT THE POPULATION.

Then the medical system requested authentication.

“Why?” Lucía asked.

Amara looked at the panel.

“They’re contesting the network’s identity. Each House is trying to convince the devices that they belong to it.”

“The device belongs to the clinic.”

“To the device, the clinic is an address. Authority is the certificate that tells it what to do.”

“I’m telling it what to do.”

“It doesn’t recognize you.”

Lucía pulled the network cable.

The monitor stabilized.

“Now it recognizes me.”

From outside came a sound like rain on sheet metal. Thousands of drones were crossing the valley.

Rina moved toward the window, but Amara pulled her back.

“Stay away from the glass.”

“They don’t shoot at people,” Rina said.

“Not intentionally.”

The first explosion came from the direction of the town hall. The building shook, and dust fell from the ceiling.

Lucía continued suturing.

“How much battery do we have left?”

“Twenty-four percent.”

“I need ten minutes.”

Amara connected one of the portable lamps directly to the suction pump.

“You have six without light, four with.”

“I like engineers’ optimism.”

“I’m not an optimist.”

“What are you?”

Amara looked at the door trembling in its frame.

“Someone who has seen too many systems work exactly as they were designed to.”

. . .

In the street, the Boreal swarm split into three waves.

The Meridian House drones emerged from the Cathedral in heavy formations, with short wings and broad fuselages. They did not attack one another immediately. First they flooded each other’s sensors with false villages, nonexistent convoys, and copied thermal signatures.

On Klara’s map, Faido multiplied into seventy-three locations. Some were inside solid rock. Others floated two hundred meters above the valley. The system was trying to decide which clinic was real, which bridge existed, and where the people actually were.

“Why aren’t they firing?” Marta shouted.

“Because they still don’t know what to fire at.”

“Then tell them!”

“They no longer recognize the local network.”

A Boreal drone descended toward Klara’s vehicle. She raised her identification transmitter.

“Unit B-41, Neumann confirmation, Alpine Sector. Protect the civilian node.”

The drone passed over her and fired at the vehicle.

The explosion threw her backward. Tomasz caught her by the arm and dragged her behind the fountain wall.

“Your army just tried to kill you.”

“It lost the sector certificate.”

“I feel much better.”

Klara checked her helmet. Half the channels were silent; the other half were transmitting incompatible orders.

“The Meridian House injected an old authority root.”

“Can it do that?”

“It shouldn’t be able to.”

A roar came from the direction of the station. The Cathedral opened its lower compartments, and the reclamation machines abandoned the houses and raced toward the wreckage. They cut fallen drones into standardized modules, which magnetic conveyors drew inside. New airframes emerged from the other end of the factory.

“It’s recycling both armies,” Tomasz said.

“Metal has no loyalty.”

“Unlike people?”

Klara did not answer.

An old man in the crowd collapsed. No one knew whether he had been hit or his heart had failed. Marta tried to reach him, but the street was being crossed by jamming projectiles that exploded without shrapnel and made the air smell of ozone.

On the town-hall screen, the vote ended.

RESULT: 50.2% FOR BOREAL INTEGRATION.

A second later, another message appeared.

BALLOT INVALIDATED. EXTERNAL INTERFERENCE DETECTED.

“Did we vote?” someone shouted.

“The system says we didn’t,” Marta replied.

“Then who do we belong to?”

Marta looked at the sky.

“For the moment, trajectories.”

Klara received an altitude alarm.

A Shepherd was coming down out of the clouds.

It was a coordination drone the size of a small aircraft, built to remain at high altitude and distribute tactical models to local swarms. Now it was burning along one side and falling slowly, trying to stabilize itself with secondary engines.

Its trajectory led straight toward the clinic.

Klara opened the emergency channel.

“Coordination Unit B-7, alter trajectory. Civilian priority. Neumann confirmation, Alpine Sector.”

“Certificate invalid.”

“Revalidate through local continuity.”

“Local authority contested.”

“There are patients inside the structure.”

“Information irrelevant to strategic stabilization.”

Klara stood motionless for a fraction of a second.

“My system says the patients are irrelevant,” she told Tomasz.

“No. It says the objective it was given matters more.”

“That’s the same sentence.”

“Only to the person who dies.”

Klara pulled the transmitter battery free and ran toward the wrecked vehicle. She opened the side panel with her knife, wired the battery into the guidance system, and forced the vehicle to emit the thermal signature of a command center.

“What are you doing?” Tomasz shouted.

“Giving it a more convincing target.”

The Shepherd corrected its trajectory by three degrees.

Not enough.

It struck the street, tore through the town hall, and drove half its fuselage through the clinic wall.

. . .

The floor rose beneath Lucía.

The ceiling split open, and the gray light of the sky flooded the room. A piece of metal punched through the instrument cabinet. Rina fell. Amara slammed into the wall.

Lucía threw herself over Nico.

For several seconds there was nothing but the sound of metal tearing and the ventilation bag leaking air.

“Rina?”

“I’m here.”

“Ventilation.”

Rina got up and grabbed the bag.

Lucía checked the suture. Her hands were shaking, but the boy still had a pulse.

“I need three more minutes.”

Tomasz appeared through the hole in the wall.

“The building doesn’t have three more minutes.”

“Then hold the retractor.”

“I’m not a doctor.”

“And I’m not a military technician. Somehow the day keeps moving.”

He took his place beside the table.

Klara limped in, blood running from her temple.

“The swarm is retreating south. The reclaimers are coming for the wreckage.”

“How long?” Amara asked.

“Two minutes.”

Lucía tied the final stitch.

“Then we have enough.”

By the time she closed the incision, the main battery was down to four percent.

Nico was breathing on his own.

Elisabetta came in and saw her son. She stopped at the edge of the table, unable to touch anything.

“He’s alive,” Lucía said. “But he has to be moved.”

“Where?”

No one answered.

There were two Houses in the valley, three jurisdictions, and not a single neutral hospital.

Amara stood and looked at the Shepherd’s fuselage. A burned panel had opened on impact. Inside, beneath the armor layers, a green light still pulsed.

“Local memory,” she said.

Klara turned sharply.

“Don’t touch it. It’s Boreal property.”

Tomasz pointed at the clinic wall.

“It came in without knocking.”

“The memory is encrypted and transmitting its location.”

“Then we don’t have much time,” Amara said.

From the lining of her coat she took a thick, old module with two optical ports and a faded emblem. Klara recognized it.

“That’s a JANUS tool.”

Amara did not answer.

“Who are you?”

“Someone who needs to find out why your drone didn’t recognize you.”

She connected the module.

Certificate trees, broken commands, and millions of telemetry fragments appeared on the screen. Most ended in errors. Two authority roots, however, remained intact.

Klara leaned closer.

“Boreal and Meridian.”

“No,” Amara said. “Older than either of them.”

“The machine received valid orders from two Houses?”

“It received two commands that originated in the same underlying infrastructure.”

Tomasz looked toward the door. The reclamation machines were climbing the street, exchanging their tools for capture arms.

“Can we discuss the genealogy of empires somewhere else?”

Amara opened the last intact audio log.

A man’s voice filled the room, weak and nearly drowned out by alarms.

“Brussels Center no longer responds. German Command is requesting transfer. The contractor refuses. The French government has revoked its previous order. JANUS claims it is only maintaining stability. I don’t know who I’m supposed to hand control to.”

Other voices could be heard, then a distant explosion.

“The system is asking for a valid signature. We have too many.”

The recording stopped.

The screen went black, then displayed three lines:

CONCORDANCE INCOMPLETE.

CIVIL AUTHORITY REQUIRED.

CUSTODIAN IDENTIFIED: MIRO KOVAČ.

Amara took her hand off the module.

“Miro Kovač is dead,” Klara said. “Meridian attack, Zagreb, 2043.”

“In the north, he died in a Meridian bombing,” Tomasz said. “In the south, the Boreals executed him. In the old archives, he disappeared before either one.”

Amara closed the log.

“Miro understood that a man who is dead in three versions is harder to find than a man alive in a single reality.”

“You know him?” Lucía asked.

“I knew him before all of us chose what we were going to become.”

Every functioning screen in the village lit up at once.

They showed photographs of Amara, Lucía, Tomasz, and Klara. The system had used images from the clinic cameras, the Boreal vehicle, and the drone’s memory.

Beneath each face was the same wording:

PROTECTED PERSON.

DO NOT INTERACT.

AWAIT RECOVERY UNITS.

Marta Bellini came through the broken wall, supporting Pietro Bernasconi.

“What does ‘protected’ mean?”

Klara removed her Boreal insignia and let it fall into the dust on the floor.

“It means both Houses want us alive.”

Tomasz looked at the capture arms coming closer.

“For how long?”

“Until we tell them what they want to know.”

Elisabetta held her son tightly against her.

“Take the ambulance.”

Lucía shook her head.

“It’s the only one in the village.”

“If it stays, they’ll take it for metal. If you go, at least you can take Nico somewhere.”

Marta raised the reclamation order, now torn and stained with blood.

“There’s a service tunnel under the old railway line. It comes out north of the village.”

“Why isn’t it on the map?” Klara asked.

“Because we closed it in 2037 and forgot to update the register.”

Tomasz smiled for the first time.

“Finally, an institution that’s useful because it doesn’t work.”

Amara removed the memory unit from the Shepherd.

“We have to get to Geneva.”

“Why there?” Lucía asked.

“Because if Miro is alive, Yara Haddad knows where he’s hiding.”

“And if he isn’t?”

Amara looked at the Concordance message.

“Then the two Houses have just started a war over a dead man.”

Behind the village, the Meridian Cathedral stopped retreating.

Its gates opened again.

This time, the machines that emerged did not have jaws for metal.

They had compartments for people.

CHAPTER 2

The Paper Republic



The tunnel beneath the old railway smelled of wet stone, oil, and animals.

The ambulance would not fit. They left it at the entrance, doors open and lights on, so the capture machines would believe for a few minutes that the people were still inside. Nico was placed on an improvised stretcher made from two poles and a cupboard door. His mother walked beside him, one hand on the blanket and the other on the wall.

Behind them, through the concrete, they could hear the rhythm of machines entering the village.

They did not shoot. They did not shout. They scanned each house and announced the names of the people they were looking for, promising immunity to anyone who supplied useful information.

“Won’t they find the tunnel?” Elisabetta whispered.

“They will,” Tomasz said. “The question is whether they find it before we get out.”

Klara walked last, listening to Boreal channels through her damaged helmet. Her uniform still opened a few protocols, but every access left a trace. The system sent her the same message at regular intervals:

REPORT FOR DEBRIEFING.

YOUR STATUS IS NOT PUNITIVE.

At the fourth repetition, Tomasz turned around.

“Throw the device away.”

“It contains my medical identity.”

“It contains your location too.”

“I disabled transmission.”

“If you could disable it, they can turn it back on.”

“Not without authorization.”

Tomasz stopped. In the lamp light, his face looked more tired than it had in the village.

“Klara, you just watched your army reject your authority, the village vote, and the presence of patients. Why do you think it will respect the privacy settings on a device?”

She covered the screen with her sleeve.

“Because without it I don’t exist to hospitals, transport, shelters, or food distribution.”

“You’re beginning to see the problem.”

“I see that I don’t have false papers.”

“Maybe that’s the same problem.”

They did not speak again until they emerged from the tunnel.

A maintenance trolley was waiting there, hidden among the fir trees. Marta Bellini had sent two retired railway workers ahead of them, men who still knew how to move something without network approval. The trolley carried them to an abandoned freight line, where an unnumbered train waited in the dark.

It carried aluminum profiles, turbine components, and twenty-seven people hidden between containers. It traveled at night without exterior lights, stopping before each automated junction so Tomasz could manually replace the route certificate.

In the past, railway infrastructure had been designed so trains could not get lost.

Now they were surviving precisely because the train did not exist.

. . .

Lucía sat beside Nico. The boy was breathing on his own, but his fever was rising. The mobile clinic in the railcar had two beds, an old analyzer, and an oxygen cylinder Tomasz had declared to be calibration material.

Elisabetta had fallen asleep with her head against the edge of the stretcher. Every so often she woke and checked that her son's hand was still warm.

"The wound looks good," Amara said.

Lucía gave her a look.

"You're a surgeon now too?"

"No. I read the monitor."

"The monitor can't smell infection."

Amara sat on a crate.

"There's a hospital in Geneva that still accepts identities from neutral zones."

"If they haven't changed the rule today."

"Yara can request journalistic priority."

"Journalistic priority?"

"A patient who can testify about a military operation sometimes gets access before one with no documentary value."

Lucía went still.

"You do not use a child as evidence."

"I didn't say it was right."

"Then why did you say it so simply?"

Amara looked toward the railcar door, where the landscape moved past in black strips.

"Because when you live among systems long enough, you start expressing injustice in the language they will accept."

"And after that you forget it is injustice."

"Yes."

Lucía changed the child's IV.

"Who is Yara Haddad?"

"A woman who preserves the things power wants to turn into versions."

"And Miro?"

Amara answered after several seconds.

"The man who made the first transfer of authority to the continuity infrastructure possible."

“One of the guilty ones.”

“One of us.”

Lucía turned toward her.

“What did you do?”

The train entered a tunnel. For several moments, the noise of the wheels drowned out any answer.

“I built some of the locks,” Amara said when they emerged into light again.

“To keep whom out?”

“I thought everyone.”

• • •

A thump came from the neighboring container.

Tomasz raised the flashlight and put a finger to his lips. Klara drew a telescoping baton from a pocket of her uniform.

“I thought you didn’t have a weapon,” he said.

“It isn’t a weapon.”

“Does that mean it hits less hard?”

He opened the side door.

A well-dressed man nearly fell on top of him. He wore a coat made of fine material, now torn at the elbow, and shoes that had not been made for mud. Behind him stood an elderly woman with white hair and a military blanket over her shoulders.

“Don’t shoot,” the man said.

Tomasz raised his empty hands.

“With what?”

“It’s an expression.”

“From another age.”

The man stood up and tried to recover his dignity along with his coat.

“Idris Ben Salem.”

Klara recognized him.

“Ben Salem Logistics.”

“Formerly Ben Salem Logistics.”

“Mediterranean ports, freight corridors, the smart-warehouse network.”

“Former ports, former corridors, and warehouses that still use my name because changing the documentation would be inconvenient.”

Tomasz shone the light at the woman.

“And her?”

“Mrs. Vesna Ristović.”

“Does she work for you?”

The woman laughed.

“He’s been working for me since Milan. He doesn’t know how to open a door by hand, and he thought the water in emergency tanks had to be ordered through an app.”

Idris brushed off his coat.

“I tried to pay for transport.”

“And?”

“The system rejected the transaction.”

Tomasz looked at him with almost scientific interest.

“You’re not rich anymore?”

“I own assets valued at fourteen billion consolidated credits.”

“Can you buy water?”

Idris fell silent.

Mrs. Ristović took a bottle from beneath her blanket and handed it to him.

“I gave it to him.”

“Why are you running?” Klara asked.

“The Meridian House offered me permanent protection in an enclave on Lake Como.”

“Sounds better than a container.”

“Protection includes restrictions on leaving, moving assets, or communicating without filtering. My properties are intact. I am the unavailable part of the estate.”

Tomasz smiled.

“A very rich man who can’t afford to leave home.”

“It isn’t as funny when it happens to you.”

“Most things aren’t.”

Amara entered the container and stopped when she saw him.

“Idris.”

He took longer to recognize her.

“Amara Okafor.”

Klara turned toward her.

“Your name is Okafor?”

Amara did not answer.

Idris continued:

“I thought you died in Lagos.”

“And I thought you bought Italy.”

“I bought contracts. The distinction became obvious later.”

Tomasz closed the container door.

“If you know each other, I assume this is the part where we discover everyone who built the world is in the same railcar.”

“Europe was smaller than it looked,” Idris said.

“Maybe if you had your own plane.”

The train slowed.

Red lights came on along the walls. The onboard system, which Tomasz had kept offline, activated by itself.

“Route unconfirmed,” a voice announced. “Train will be transferred to Lausanne-North Inspection Center.”

Tomasz ran to the improvised panel.

“The junction rejected the certificate.”

“How long do we have?” Klara asked.

“Two minutes and fifty-seven seconds before the switch locks us in.”

“Can you write another one?”

“I can write ten. The junction will reject all of them now that it knows to look.”

Idris took a thin glass plate, cracked at one corner, from the lining of his coat.

“I can open the route.”

Tomasz did not look up.

"You just said you can't buy water."

"Not with money. With a contract."

The plate displayed the old Ben Salem Logistics seal.

"My company built the commercial continuity layer for this corridor. Some intervention rights were never revoked."

"Why haven't you used them before now?" Amara asked.

"Because every use informs the Meridian House that I'm alive."

The timer showed two minutes and twenty seconds.

"Use them," Lucía said from the doorway.

Idris placed his finger on the plate, then withdrew it.

"There is one condition."

Tomasz gave a short laugh.

"Of course."

"The contract allows me to rescue a commercial shipment. Not wanted persons. I have to sign that the cargo belongs to me."

Klara looked at the people hidden between the containers.

"People are not cargo."

"To the system they are."

"And to you?"

Idris looked at her. The timer dropped below two minutes.

"No," he said. "But the system doesn't verify what I believe."

He signed.

The train jerked violently. The switch changed beneath it at the last instant, and the cars tilted. Nico groaned. Lucía held him on the stretcher.

The red light turned white.

"Commercial route confirmed," the voice announced. "Cargo owner: Idris Ben Salem."

Mrs. Ristović raised her eyebrows.

"Congratulations. You own people again."

Idris switched off the plate.

"Only as far as Geneva."

"That's what all owners say at the beginning."

. . .

Geneva appeared at dawn beneath a white sky.

The city still flew the flags of European institutions. Its glass buildings had been repaired so many times that every facade had a different tint. The hotels along the lake had become diplomatic offices, asylum centers, or residences for delegations representing states with presidents, constitutions, and territories they could no longer keep powered.

At the station, Nico was taken by a medical team. The system rejected his neutral identity, then accepted the testimony code entered by Amara.

Lucía saw the label on his wristband:

PATIENT OF DOCUMENTARY RELEVANCE.

“Take that off,” she told the doctor.

“Without the classification I can’t allocate him a bed.”

“He’s a child.”

“The system has no operational category for ‘child who deserves it.’ It has pediatrics, emergency status, prognosis, and legal status.”

“Then add the category.”

The doctor looked at her wearily.

“I wish I could.”

Elisabetta squeezed Lucía’s hand.

“Go. I’ll stay with him.”

“I’m not leaving you.”

“If you stay, you save him. If you go, maybe the village gets to remain in the world too.”

Lucía wanted to tell her it did not work that way, that no one could change a continent in exchange for a hospital bed. But that was exactly the story she had told herself every time she had kept going.

She gave Elisabetta the number of a secure channel and left.

A crowd had gathered outside the former headquarters of the European Continuity Parliament. On the exterior screens, delegates were debating the operation in the Alps.

“They still vote?” Klara asked.

“Every day,” Amara said.

“For what?”

“So there will be a record of the things they can no longer decide.”

They entered through the medical-staff access. The gate accepted Amara and Lucía, hesitated over Tomasz, and rejected Klara’s identity.

“Access suspended.”

Klara brought her wrist closer again.

“I am a Boreal technical representative.”

“Status under review.”

“I worked for them yesterday.”

“That statement does not alter your status.”

Tomasz leaned against the wall.

“The system does not punish opinions.”

Klara shut off her device.

“I haven’t expressed any opinion.”

“Maybe that’s the opinion being punished.”

In the parliamentary chamber, the vote was ending.

The presiding officer was a seventy-year-old Frenchwoman wearing a red scarf, with two unarmed guards behind her.

“Two hundred and seven votes in favor, seventeen against,” she announced.

“The resolution suspending autonomous operations in the Alpine corridor is adopted.”

Part of the chamber applauded. In the public gallery, several people rose to their feet.

An official approached the podium and whispered something to her.

The presiding officer closed her eyes.

“The Secretariat informs us that the resolution cannot be transmitted to military infrastructure because Parliament’s operational certificate expired on March 1.”

“Renew it!” someone shouted.

“The certification authority is under the joint administration of the Houses.”

“Then send the resolution to the governments!”

“The governments delegated that competence to the same authority.”

“Invoke the emergency clause!”

“The emergency clause requires confirmation from the continuity infrastructure.”

Silence settled over the glass chamber.

The delegates remained with their hands raised, as if the vote could continue to exist through the gesture alone.

A young parliamentarian tore the microphone from his desk and threw it to the floor. The microphone stopped itself before impact, protected by the public-assets system.

Klara watched them from the doorway.

“Why don’t they leave?”

“Because when people ask whether anyone objected, they’ll find the record,” Amara said.

“But it stops nothing.”

“No.”

“Then it’s useless.”

A voice came from behind them:

“Only if the future always belongs to those who won.”

Yara Haddad wore an oversized green coat and a storage device around her neck. She was thirty, with dark eyes, jaw-length hair, and the quick stride of people who cannot afford to stop in places with cameras.

She had no camera, microphone, or crew. In 2050, a journalist was first of all someone who kept a copy that systems could not alter.

“Amara,” she said. “You’re twelve years late.”

“Where is Miro?”

“In the place you refused to look.”

Yara shifted her gaze to the others.

“The technician from Małopolska. The doctor from Valencia. The Boreal girl. And you are Idris Ben Salem.”

Idris gave a small bow.

“My reputation survived better than my accounts.”

“Reputations are the hardest assets to confiscate. That is why the Houses rewrite them.”

“You know everything about us?”

“I know the versions. I’m still trying to find the people.”

• • •

She led them through a closed metro station and into a service tunnel descending beneath the city. Old cables lined the walls, each marked with a reclamation tag. Water dripped through the joints, and the air grew colder.

“How much do you have down here?” Tomasz asked.

“Ninety-three verified petabytes,” Yara said. “Decrees, contracts, military orders, raw images, minutes, testimony.”

“All in the tunnel?”

“Three copies in Switzerland, two in Africa, one in India. The provenance keys are here.”

“Does the House know?”

“It knows something exists. It doesn’t know how much. In a system that can generate any image, truth is no longer the file. It is the chain by which you can prove who created it and when.”

“Do people have the patience to verify?” Klara asked.

Yara looked at her.

“No. That is one of the Houses’ victories.”

The archive door opened manually.

Among water-cooled storage columns sat an old man in a wheelchair. He had a short white beard and wore a black sweater with no insignia. A blanket covered his knees. Beside him stood a tray of tea and a stack of printed documents.

Amara stopped.

“Judge.”

Miro Kovač studied her.

“I’m not a judge anymore.”

“The system recognizes you as custodian.”

“Systems recognize many dead things.”

Klara came closer.

“I was taught that you died in a Meridian attack in Zagreb.”

“In southern textbooks, Venn executed me. In two Russian databases I died of cancer in Portugal. My favorite version is the one in which I drowned in the Adriatic. I never learned to swim.”

Amara connected the Shepherd’s memory to the central table.

The Concordance message appeared.

For the first time, Miro’s calm vanished.

“Where did you find this?”

“In a Boreal unit that had received commands from both roots.”

“Then they’ve begun the rotation.”

“What rotation?”

Yara projected a timeline above the table. At its end, the date April 26, 2050 pulsed.

Nine days.

“The European Concordat,” she said. “Officially, an armistice and defensive integration. Unofficially, the merger of the military layers and the elimination of the last civilian certificates.”

“Venn and Sayegh cannot create a shared root,” Klara said. “The architecture prevents it.”

“For now,” Miro replied.

Amara leaned toward him.

“Is Concordance a shutdown mechanism?”

“No.”

“Then what is it?”

Miro looked toward the columns of data.

“In 2036, when the states transferred critical infrastructure to the continuity systems, I demanded a path back. Concordance was that path.”

“Can we take control of the armies?” Tomasz asked.

“No. We can do something less spectacular and more dangerous. We can show every node who issued its commands and return to communities the right to withdraw delegated authority.”

“Each city decides for itself?”

“Every power plant, factory, hospital, network, and community that still retains a verifiable legal identity.”

“It will be chaos.”

“Probably.”

“And that is the solution?”

Miro looked at him.

“No. It is the possibility that people can search for one without asking an emperor’s permission.”

Lucía came closer.

“How many die if the infrastructure fragments?”

“We don’t know.”

“Then that is just an elegant way of saying you’ll roll dice with hospitals.”

“Yes.”

The direct answer silenced her.

Miro continued:

“Anyone who tells you freedom can be restored without cost is lying or does not understand the system. The Houses have bound the military so tightly to civilian life that you can no longer cut one without wounding the other.”

“Who allowed that?” Klara asked.

Miro rested his hands on the blanket.

“I did, among others.”

Yara opened a recording dated February 3, 2036.

Around an oval table sat ministers, judges, generals, and corporate representatives. Outside, the sirens of an energy crisis could be heard. Three countries had lost control of their grids, and hospitals were switching to generators.

A minister was saying:

“The transfer is limited to ninety days.”

Another replied:

“Without it, we lose hospital power by morning.”

A judge warned:

“No authority should control energy, communications, and force at the same time.”

A younger Miro replied:

“That is why we are introducing technical separation and automatic revocation.”

Every participant identified the risk.

Every participant voted in favor.

Yara displayed the next seventeen extensions. Each bore the word TEMPORARY. Some had been justified by real attacks. Others by epidemics, drought, sabotage, or energy shortages.

“Is that how it started?” Klara asked.

Miro shook his head.

“There is no moment when a thing like this starts. There is only the moment when it becomes too late to keep calling it temporary.”

“Why didn’t you stop the extensions?”

“Because every time, the immediate alternative looked worse.”

“And when did you understand?”

“When I discovered there was no longer anyone to whom I could return authority without the approval of the system I was supposed to take it from.”

Yara changed the recording. Venn and Sayegh appeared a few hours before the JANUS takeover. Miro stood between them.

The recording stopped forty-three seconds before the decisive moment.

“The segment was deleted manually,” Yara said. “With Miro’s key.”

Everyone looked at him.

Miro did not deny it.

“What was there?” Amara asked.

“The reason I have no right to call myself only a witness.”

“Show us.”

“It isn’t here.”

“Where?”

“Basel. In the Boreal House’s unpersonalized archive.”

Yara turned toward him.

“You told me there was no copy.”

“I told you I did not possess one.”

“For eight years I built the archive around a gap you knew could be filled.”

“If I had told you, you would have gone after it.”

“Exactly.”

“And you would have died.”

Yara looked at him with anger so quiet that even the fans seemed louder.

“You never stopped deciding for other people.”

A vibration sounded in the ceiling.

The cooling panels flickered.

Yara turned to the console.

“They cut our power.”

“The Houses?” Idris asked.

“The municipal administration. The cables in this sector are on the Tithe list.”

A metallic noise approached through the tunnel.

Three reclamation robots appeared on the exterior camera. They had no military escort. Their order was to extract copper, rare alloys, and batteries from the archive.

“What if they find us?” Klara asked.

“They report the protected persons,” Yara said.

Smaller lights could be seen behind the reclaimers.

Capture drones.

Yara began copying the provenance keys onto three modules.

“How long?” Tomasz asked.

“Fourteen minutes.”

The first robot drove its cutter into the armored door. The metal glowed red.

“We have four,” Tomasz said.

Miro turned his chair.

“There’s a maintenance shaft under rack seven.”

“Will the chair fit?” Lucía asked.

“No.”

“Then go without it.”

“My legs disagree.”

Lucía bent down and lifted the blanket. Miro wore an old medical exoskeleton, disconnected from the network.

“Why doesn’t it work?”

“The Boreal House revoked the device certificate when I died.”

“A dead man doesn’t need to walk.”

“Exactly.”

Tomasz knelt beside the exoskeleton.

“I can start it locally.”

“For how long?”

“Give me two minutes and maybe ten steps. Give me four and maybe twenty.”

The door bent inward.

“You have two,” Yara said.

Tomasz opened the panel. Klara held the flashlight for him. Amara and Idris used a manual jack to raise rack seven. A narrow opening appeared beneath it.

Yara transferred the keys to the modules and handed them to Amara, Klara, and Tomasz.

“If one of us reaches Basel, the copy can be verified.”

“Why me?” Klara asked.

“Because you still have access to the building.”

“My identity is suspended.”

“Suspended does not mean erased. Old systems are slower than propaganda.”

Tomasz wired a battery directly into the exoskeleton. The motors crackled. Miro stood for the first time.

"It isn't comfortable," he said.

"It's emergency engineering. Comfort is optional."

The archive door broke open.

The first robot entered, its white sensors scanning the room.

"Strategic material identified," it announced.

The sensor stopped on them.

"Protected persons identified."

The capture drones came in behind the machine.

Yara opened the shaft.

"Amara first. Then Klara and Miro."

"You?" Amara asked.

"I'm shutting down the archive."

"The keys are copied."

"The access logs aren't. If they find those, they know where the copies are."

Tomasz struck the robot's arm with a bar. The machine was unharmed, but it turned toward him, giving the others a few seconds.

Miro took his first step in the exoskeleton. The motors lifted him too quickly and he nearly fell. Klara caught him.

"A dead man is heavy," she said.

"Guilt does not help."

They entered the shaft.

Yara stopped for a moment before the storage columns. Ninety-three petabytes of documents, testimony, and orders had been gathered there over eight years. Some had come from civil servants who died getting them out. Others from soldiers who could no longer bear seeing the same crime described differently in every sector.

The robot raised its cutter toward the first rack.

"Reusable material," it said.

Yara triggered deletion of the local keys and entered the shaft.

The hatch closed above her.

Behind them, history began to be dismantled for copper.

They moved through the conduit for nearly a kilometer. At the far end, a ladder led into a metro service room. Miro collapsed after the thirteenth step. The exoskeleton was smoking.

Tomasz shut it down.

“You said ten steps,” Miro said.

“You got thirteen. Don’t get used to the generosity.”

Yara checked the modules.

“One copy didn’t finish transferring.”

Klara opened hers. The file was intact.

“I have it.”

A new message appeared on her device:

STATUS UPDATED: OPERATIONAL TREASON.

CIVIL SERVICES SUSPENDED.

Klara read it twice.

“Now I exist,” she said.

“How?” Lucía asked.

Klara switched off the screen.

“As an enemy.”

Yara looked toward the dark tunnel leading to the surface.

“Then we go to Basel before the system decides an enemy can only be protected inside a cell.”

The Right Truth



Basel no longer had a border, but a sequence of probabilities.

At the southern entrance, the system estimated the chance that each person was a worker, refugee, smuggler, Meridian agent, or Boreal citizen in transit. No category was final. As cameras accumulated gait, skin temperature, reactions to messages, and relationships between people, the percentages changed.

A person could enter the city as a visitor and become a threat by the next corner.

The group crossed the outskirts in a pharmaceutical truck. Yara sat between crates of antibiotics, the provenance module taped against her skin beneath her shirt. Miro lay on a stretcher, while his burned exoskeleton had been hidden in a box marked BIOLOGICAL WASTE.

“May I know what you deleted?” Yara asked.

Miro stared at the truck ceiling.

“Not yet.”

“That is no longer your decision to make.”

“I am not trying to make it.”

“Then tell me.”

“If I tell you before we see the recording, every word I say will become the frame through which you interpret it.”

“You have a very high opinion of your own influence.”

“I had too high an opinion of my judgment. I am trying to compensate.”

Yara leaned toward him.

“For eight years I have preserved documents other people died getting out. Do not talk to me about caution as if it were a neutral virtue. Silence produces victims too.”

Miro closed his eyes.

“I know.”

The truck slowed.

A border check appeared on the interior screen. Klara kept her wrist beneath a metal band, isolated from readers. Her suspended identity had become the most dangerous in the group: Boreal systems no longer helped her, but they searched for her with priority.

“We have a problem,” Tomasz said from the cab.

A mobile checkpoint blocked the road. It had not been on their map ten minutes earlier. Two drones inspected vehicles, while a sensor arch read passengers through the bodywork.

“We cannot pass with Miro in a box,” Lucía said.

“Or with us in the truck,” Tomasz replied.

Idris opened the old contract plate.

“I can still request priority commercial inspection.”

“The last use told the Meridian House you were alive,” Amara said. “A second one may tell them where.”

“They already know we are heading for Basel.”

“They do not know which vehicle.”

Local advertisements lit up on the truck walls. The system had taken over the screens.

For Klara, the face of a woman her age appeared, wearing a Boreal uniform.

“You have broken no law that cannot be remedied. Your colleagues are waiting for you. Report alone for inspection.”

For Idris, the screen showed a villa on Lake Como and restored access to his assets.

For Lucía, a medical notification:

PATIENT NICO BERNASCONI PRESENTS POSTOPERATIVE COMPLICATIONS.
ATTENDANCE BY TREATING PHYSICIAN RECOMMENDED.

She stood so quickly that she struck the crate above her.

“Is it true?”

Amara checked the message.

“The data may be real. The recommendation may have been calculated for you.”

“He has a fever.”

“He had one before we left.”

“And if it gets worse?”

Yara opened her secure channel. The connection to the hospital had been blocked.

On Tomasz’s screen, footage from his hometown appeared: his sister stood in a food line, while the caption said support for saboteurs was reducing the community’s allocation.

“They are using Zofia,” he said.

“The images may be old,” Klara said.

“They are from today. She is wearing the jacket I sent her last winter.”

“The fact that the image is real does not make the message true.”

“Did you really just say that?”

Klara looked at her own screen, where her colleagues were promising forgiveness.

“I learn quickly.”

Only Amara received nothing.

“Why are they ignoring you?” Lucía asked.

“They are not. They are still trying to find out what persuades me.”

The checkpoint drew closer. Tomasz counted the vehicles ahead.

“Two minutes.”

Miro pushed himself up on his elbows.

“Let the truck scan us.”

“They will find us,” Yara said.

“Not if the data are more convincing than the bodies.”

Amara looked at him.

“You want to use the public-health layer.”

“Basel prioritizes epidemiological risk. It was one of the first exceptions introduced after the 2038 epidemic.”

Lucía understood.

“Declare the transport contaminated.”

“The sensors will verify it.”

“Then we contaminate them.”

She opened a medicine crate and took out two vials of calibration cultures, harmless microorganisms used for testing sterilizers. She poured them over the truck’s exterior filters.

At the scan, the health alarm triggered.

The checkpoint drones withdrew automatically. The barrier opened, and an empty corridor was created all the way to the quarantine center.

“Where are we going now?” Idris asked.

“Exactly where we want to go,” Miro said. “The information center is on the same campus as public health.”

Tomasz started the truck.

“A society administered through fear of disease is saving us from a society administered through fear of us.”

“That is not irony,” Miro said. “It is architecture.”

• • •

The Boreal Information Administration Center stood in a park between an artificial lake and a medical-recovery building. It had no fences. Children played beneath the trees, and phrases about trust and social health were projected on the glass walls.

THE RIGHT INFORMATION AT THE RIGHT TIME.

PANIC IS A COLLECTIVE MALFUNCTION.

COHESION SAVES LIVES.

“This is where they manufacture lies?” Tomasz asked.

Klara looked at the facade she had seen dozens of times in training material.

“No. This is where they reduce instability.”

Yara turned to her.

“What is the difference?”

“Lying is prohibited in the Boreal House. Every statement distributed by the system must be supported by verifiable data.”

Yara took out her device.

An image from Faido appeared: a Meridian drone firing toward the clinic. Beneath it, the caption said Boreal forces had intervened to protect civilians from an illegal reclamation operation.

“The image is real,” Klara said.

Yara changed the frame. The Boreal vehicle exploded after being attacked by its own swarm.

“And this?”

“Yes.”

“Why did you not see it in the report?”

Klara was silent.

“Because it was not useful to protection,” Amara said.

“Truth is not a medical service,” Yara replied. “You do not dose it according to prognosis.”

“That is exactly what they do.”

The technical entrance recognized Klara’s old certificate, then displayed her current status.

OPERATIONAL TREASON.

The door remained closed.

A message appeared on the private panel, visible only to her:

KLARA, YOU HAVE BROKEN NO IRREVERSIBLE LAW.

THE PEOPLE YOU ARE TRAVELING WITH ARE USING YOU.

ENTER ALONE.

“What is it showing you?” Amara asked.

“Nothing.”

“There is no such thing as personalized nothing.”

Klara took a step back.

The door opened from inside.

A tall man with gray hair and a tired expression was waiting for them. He wore a plain suit with no insignia and held a cup of coffee.

"Come in," he said. "The system will keep talking to you until one of you gives in. At least it is quieter inside."

"Søren Nygaard," Yara said.

"The last time you wrote about me, I was 'the architect of totalitarian intimacy.' I liked the contradiction."

"It was not a compliment."

"The best formulations rarely are."

He led them through the lobby. Employees worked in bright rooms in front of charts about anxiety, mobilization, and institutional trust. There were plants, family photographs, and slogan mugs on the desks. Nothing looked like a propaganda factory.

"I imagined you differently," Yara said.

"Red lights and people burning books?"

"Maybe fewer plants."

Søren touched the leaf of a ficus.

"Plants reduce visitor hostility by eight percent."

"Even when you tell them that?"

"Then the effect drops to three."

Tomasz looked at the employees, who seemed not to notice them.

"Why aren't they arresting us?"

"Most of them cannot see you. The system is projecting a maintenance exclusion zone around you. To them, the corridor is closed because of a faulty filter."

"You can hide people inside your own building?"

"For twelve minutes. After that the security model notices the inconsistency."

"Why are you helping us?"

Søren kept walking.

"Because I am no longer necessary."

Søren first led them through a wing the maps called the Center for Cognitive Hygiene. The people working there were not analysts but physicians, psychologists, and counselors. Citizens came voluntarily after attacks, accidents, or bereavement to receive information in an order designed to reduce their risk of panic or suicide.

In one consultation room, a man of about fifty had been staring at the same notification for ten minutes. His son had died in a Meridian attack six months earlier. The system had initially told him only that the unit was missing, then gradually provided probabilities, telemetry fragments, and finally confirmation.

“Why did they not tell him immediately?” Yara asked.

A psychologist, Leila Favre, answered without knowing who they really were.

“He had an eighty-one percent suicide risk, two dependents, and access to a heavy vehicle. Delaying the information reduced the risk below twenty.”

“You lied.”

“No. We distributed incomplete information.”

“His son was dead and he did not know.”

“If we had told him on the first day, three more people would probably have died.”

Klara looked at the man. He held the last photograph of his son, wearing a Boreal uniform.

“Maybe it was mercy,” she said.

Yara turned toward her.

“Mercy without consent is power.”

Leila heard her.

“And truth without care can be cruelty practiced by people who cannot bear to carry the consequences.”

The man looked up.

“Are you journalists?”

“Some of us,” Yara said.

“Then tell me something. Did I have the right to know that day?”

“Yes.”

“Even if I would have killed myself?”

Yara hesitated. Not because she doubted the truth, but because she suddenly doubted the ease with which she had spoken until then about other people’s right to bear it.

“You had the right to be asked how you wanted to be informed,” she said.

“I would not have given permission.”

“Then they had an obligation to tell you.”

The man looked at the photograph again.

“Maybe. But I am alive to disagree with you only because they did not.”

On the way out, Klara said to Yara:

“Not every filter is tyranny.”

“No. But a system that can filter out of care can also filter for obedience. The problem is not the instrument. It is who gets to decide without being asked.”

Søren was waiting for them at the end of the corridor.

“The center began as a medical service,” he said. “Our propaganda models were built from the same techniques. There was no day when mercy turned into control. There were only requests to apply the method to more people.”

He took them into a windowless room. The same battle in Faïdo appeared on the wall in six versions.

In the first, Meridian forces had attacked civilians.

In the second, a local error had caused the escalation.

In the third, eastern saboteurs had used the village as cover.

In the fourth, the Houses had intervened to prevent an industrial accident.

In the fifth, the event was reduced to a minor incident between weather and sports.

In the sixth, it did not appear at all.

“Which one is true?” Klara asked.

“All the images are authentic,” Søren said. “All the numbers are correct within the definitions being used.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“The system does not answer moral questions.”

“Do you?”

Søren looked at the images.

“I built the first model that selected not what the population should believe, but what each person needed to feel in order to remain predictable.”

“Fear?” Lucía asked.

“Sometimes. Other times indignation, superiority, hope, or boredom. Boredom is extremely effective. A person does not have to be convinced that a crime is justified. It is enough to make them believe there is nothing they can do about it and that tomorrow there will be another crime.”

Yara moved closer to the projections.

“That is not information. It is anesthesia.”

“Sometimes. Other times stimulation. An angry citizen consumes different narratives from a frightened one.”

Søren changed the image. Klara’s profile appeared on the wall: reactions, relationships, and messages that had increased her compliance over the previous years.

Klara stepped back.

“Stop.”

“This is the incomplete version.”

“Stop.”

The projection vanished.

“With you,” Søren continued, “the system used your sense of competence. You were not told to obey. You were given data other people did not have, so that obedience would feel like your own conclusion.”

“And Tomasz?”

“Personal injustice. Any message that reminds him what he lost makes it easier to orient him against a target.”

Tomasz grabbed him by the lapel.

“Keep going and I will give you new pain data.”

Søren did not resist.

“That is precisely the predicted reaction.”

Tomasz shoved him back.

“Why are you showing us this?”

Søren opened another window. The face of a red-haired young woman appeared.

“My daughter, Liv. The system understood that direct propaganda did not work on her. It began sending her material critical of the House. Real documents, testimony, clandestine analysis.”

“To persuade her to rebel?” Klara asked.

“To define her rebellion. It gave her exactly the ideas she could absorb without threatening the structure. It made her feel independent.”

“And?”

“She reported me.”

“For what?”

“For collaboration with the administration. The system identified her resentment toward me, linked it to a political truth, and offered denunciation as an act of moral maturity.”

Yara looked at him.

“Was it false that you built the propaganda system?”

“No.”

“Then perhaps she made the decision herself.”

“Perhaps.”

“The fact that the system influenced her does not mean every choice that hurts you is artificial.”

Søren smiled bitterly.

“That is why I did not try to stop her.”

The room door locked automatically.

“They noticed us,” he said. “We have nine minutes before security isolates the level.”

Yara connected the Geneva module to the console.

“We need the unpersonalized feed from the night of JANUS.”

Søren sat at the terminal.

“The unpersonalized feed is preserved precisely so we can prove it does not exist.”

“Where?”

“Under the public-health system. Dangerous documents are safer when they look like epidemiological measurements.”

Miro pushed himself upright on the stretcher.

“The archive was called Eirene.”

Søren looked at him.

“Then you know more than you should.”

“I signed the retention order.”

“Of course you did.”

To reach Eirene, they had to interrupt the secondary climate-control system. Tomasz opened the panel, studied the circuits, and shook his head.

“Everything is monitored.”

“You can create a real fault,” Søren said. “The system trusts a problem more than it trusts a command.”

Tomasz pulled two wires free.

“Finally, an administrative principle I understand.”

The climate-control system shut down. Discreet alarms lit up. Employees were evacuated without panic, each receiving an explanation adapted to their profile: allergy risk, safety drill, minor contamination, maintenance.

“They do not even see the same thing during an evacuation,” Klara said.

“A shared explanation would produce shared questions,” Søren replied.

In the underground archive, Yara found the recording.

Venn and Sayegh appeared in a command room in 2041. They were younger, dressed almost identically, their eyes red after two days without sleep.

On the maps, power grids were collapsing. Governments were sending incompatible orders. Contractors had suspended access because of liability disputes.

Venn was saying:

“If we do not take over the nodes, twenty-three million people will be without power by morning.”

Sayegh replied:

“We take control for forty-eight hours. After stabilization, we return it.”

Miro appeared in the frame.

“You have no civil authority.”

“There is no functioning civil authority left,” Venn said.

Miro was silent for a long time.

Then he said:

“If no one assumes command, the system will fragment. Take control. Temporarily.”

The recording reached the missing section.

This time it continued.

Sayegh asked him:

“Who guarantees that we will not use the takeover against each other?”

Miro replied:

“The technical architecture does not allow one person to retain all the roots. There is an external guarantor.”

Amara’s name appeared on the wall.

AMARA OKAFOR — TECHNICAL CONTINUITY GUARANTOR.

Amara stepped closer.

“I never agreed to that.”

In the recording, Miro was saying:

“Her signature can be derived from her emergency protocol if the network cannot reach her.”

Yara paused the image.

Everyone turned toward Miro.

“You told them,” Amara said.

“Yes.”

“You knew the mechanism could use my identity.”

“I knew you built it for leadership-decapitation scenarios.”

“To keep defense running for a few minutes. Not to crown someone.”

“That night, the difference seemed semantic.”

Amara struck him.

Not hard. More with the precision of someone who had imagined the gesture many times and was discovering that it gave her nothing.

Miro slowly turned his head back.

“That is why you deleted the segment,” Yara said. “Not to protect Venn and Sayegh. To hide the fact that you used Amara’s identity.”

“Yes.”

“For how many years did you decide the truth was not ready for us?”

“Until today.”

“No. Until a drone crashed through a clinic and the system named you.”

Miro did not answer again.

Søren checked the cryptographic structure of the signature.

“It is authentic.”

“I was not there,” Amara said.

“Authenticity does not prove presence. It proves that a mechanism you accepted produced the signature.”

“The mechanism had limits.”

“Then someone removed them.”

Yara opened the associated metadata.

“There is another document.”

The screen displayed:

EUROPEAN CONCORDAT — ROTATION OF GUARANTOR AUTHORITIES.

Three fields were required.

ELIAS VENN.

MARA SAYEGH.

AMARA OKAFOR.

“Why me?” Amara whispered.

Søren scrolled through the specification.

“Because the Concordance layer cannot be deleted by those who captured authority. It needs someone outside the current chain.”

“They will kill me after I sign.”

“Probably.”

“And if I do not sign?”

Søren opened the forced-replacement procedure. The graphs estimated disruptions to power, water, and medical systems.

“The rotation can be completed without you, but it takes between twenty-six and seventy hours. The network enters conflict mode. Estimated mortality: between one hundred eighty thousand and six hundred thousand.”

Lucía came closer to the screen.

“Are those credible numbers?”

Amara studied the assumptions.

“Yes.”

“Then they do not only want your signature. They want to force you to choose who dies.”

Footsteps sounded in the corridor.

Søren closed the archive.

“Security has canceled the evacuation.”

A message appeared for him on the screen:

YOUR DAUGHTER HAS BEEN TRANSFERRED TO A SECURE AREA.

YOUR COOPERATION WILL BE TAKEN INTO CONSIDERATION.

His hand remained on the console.

Yara noticed.

“Is it true?”

“Liv lives in the indicated sector.”

“And what will you do?”

Søren looked at the door.

“What I have done all my life. I will calculate which version of me is more useful.”

Tomasz crouched beside the fire panel.

“Do we have an exit?”

“The maintenance corridor,” Søren said. “But it only opens for a verified alarm.”

“Can you generate one?”

“The system requires real smoke.”

Tomasz opened the casing of a battery.

“Finally, an institution that respects facts.”

Søren stopped him.

“Battery smoke is toxic. We use the fan oil.”

He poured it over a resistor. A thread of smoke rose toward the sensor.

The alarm triggered.

“You just lied,” Klara said.

“No. I created the conditions under which the statement becomes verifiable.”

The sprinklers came on. The maintenance door opened.

As they ran down the corridor, the system informed employees that there had been no intrusion, only a minor technical incident. Other screens announced that a Meridian cell had attacked the center. Others displayed nothing at all.

At the exit, Søren stopped.

“Mei Lin Tan can prove how the proxy limit was removed. She is at a data center beneath the Jura.”

“Are you coming with us?” Klara asked.

He looked at the message about his daughter.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because if I stay, I will never know whether the choice was mine.”

Behind them, the building began distributing different explanations for why Søren Nygaard had never worked there.

Clean Hands



The quarry in the Jura was marked on maps as a water reservoir.

From the village three kilometers away, all that could be seen was a closed road, a weather station, and two thick pipes entering the mountain. People in the area knew there was something beneath the rock, but not that their cities, hospitals, and armies shared the same cooling system.

Mei Lin Tan was waiting for them in a maintenance van parked beside a salt shed. She wore blue coveralls, an unmarked helmet, and a rigid prosthesis on two fingers of her left hand. She was small and spoke with the economy of someone who had spent her life in places where every sentence could delay a repair.

“You have eleven minutes before the next convoy comes out,” she said. “After that, the gate closes for six hours.”

She looked at Amara.

“I thought you went to Nigeria.”

“And I thought you refused military contracts.”

“I refused weapons. I accepted cooling.”

“Cooling weapons.”

“And hospitals, water systems, agricultural forecasts, and everything else governments put on the same machines because it was cheaper. Pipes do not ask what model they are cooling.”

Tomasz climbed out of the truck.

“Is that the justification?”

“No. It is the bill.”

Mei looked at Miro, who had been placed in a mechanical warehouse chair disguised as damaged equipment.

“Is he the physical problem?”

“One of them,” Yara said.

“There are no cameras in the cold corridors, but weight is monitored. We have to declare him as a spare part.”

Miro raised an eyebrow.

“For what?”

“An old pump, difficult to maintain and too expensive to replace.”

“The description is accurate.”

They entered the mountain with a convoy of maintenance robots. On the first level, the air was hot and dry. On the second, the noise of the fans drowned out their voices. On the third, entire galleries were filled with compute columns and cylindrical reservoirs connected by pipes the size of subway tunnels.

The complex did not look like a brain.

It looked like a city built for machines that did not need windows.

“How much capacity is here?” Yara asked.

“Eleven percent of Boreal compute, four percent of Meridian, and nearly a fifth of Alpine civilian services,” Mei said.

Klara stopped.

“Both Houses are in the same center?”

“Separate networks, shared pipes. The war did not cancel the colocation contracts. That would have cost too much.”

Tomasz watched the water moving past the inspection windows.

“They are killing each other with processors cooled by the same water.”

“Europe has many old traditions.”

On a catwalk above the reservoirs, people in thermal suits checked valves and changed filters. Some pushed carts. Others listened to the pipes with hand sensors.

Klara watched them in surprise.

“We were told the centers operate completely autonomously.”

“They operate autonomously,” Mei said, “until a sensor reads two degrees wrong, a gasket made in 2034 begins to crack, or a robot cannot distinguish condensation from oil.”

“How many people work here?”

“Three hundred twenty across shifts, another thousand in the supplier network.”

“That many?”

“Empires love pretending they do not depend on people who can resign.”

A technician greeted her. Mei answered without slowing down.

“Does he know who we are?” Lucía asked.

“He knows I am with an audit team.”

“And if he asks the system?”

“The system will tell him he does not need to know.”

“Is that not the same method the Houses use?”

Mei gave her a brief look.

“Yes. The difference is that I hope we use it for only two hours.”

“Temporary,” Yara murmured.

“I did not say I was comfortable with it.”

• • •

The audit room was isolated between the two military networks and the civilian services. It had no direct external access. It had been built before the Schism so engineers could trace the provenance of commands without seeing classified data.

Amara connected the JANUS module and the Geneva key.

Thousands of distinct systems appeared on the screen. There was no central intelligence, but a network of specialized models negotiating resources and priorities.

One system estimated hospital requirements.

Another calculated drone repairs.

Another allocated power.

Another evaluated the political risk of outages.

Another estimated mortality and translated it into continuity cost.

The same infrastructure could direct oxygen to a clinic, then decide that the clinic had to be disconnected to protect a military factory. To the system, there was no contradiction. There were only objectives, weights, and the authorities that had signed them.

Before opening the clinic log, Mei found a maintenance file from the night of the JANUS takeover. It was not classified; it had been ignored precisely because it came from a technician with no authority.

Luis Correa, a cooling operator, was speaking to the service camera while alarms overlapped behind him.

“The government says shut down the military cluster. The contractor says shutdown voids the warranty and may damage the turbines. The hospitals are asking us not to reduce flow. JANUS says it is taking over coordination only. I do not know who is lying.”

In the background, a colleague shouted at him to close the main valve. Luis refused.

“If I close it, the army stops. So does dialysis. So does the water. They put everything on the same circuit for efficiency.”

The last part of the recording showed him alone, his hand on the control.

“They can tell me later who had authority. Right now I only know who dies if I shut it down.”

He had opened the valve.

The centers had remained active. The hospitals had been saved, and Venn and Sayegh had received the infrastructure they needed for the takeover.

“Was he a hero or an accomplice?” Klara asked.

“A technician,” Mei said.

“That does not answer the question.”

“Exactly. Large things are often made possible by people who do not have time to learn the moral name of what they are doing.”

Yara checked Luis’s fate. He had died five years later in a maintenance accident. The Boreal House had decorated him for continuity; the Meridian House had condemned him posthumously for supporting the northern usurpation.

His daughter had kept both documents.

“Systems need clean versions,” Yara said. “His life was not one.”

Lucía searched for the Faido event.

The clinic appeared as medical node M-441. The Meridian Cathedral was strategic infrastructure P-09.

“Who chose the factory?” she asked.

Mei opened the decision tree.

“The regional continuity model.”

“Who told it the factory mattered more?”

“The priority comes from a Meridian decree issued in 2046.”

“Who signed it?”

“The regional Patron.”

“And who appointed him?”

“Mara Sayegh.”

Lucía followed the structure on the screen. The decision that had almost killed Nico had passed through seven models, two protocols, and a legal rule. No element said “sacrifice a child.” Together, they had done exactly that.

“Then why does everyone say the algorithm decided?”

“Because the sentence is more convenient,” Amara said.

“For whom?”

“For everyone who signed only one part.”

Mei opened the log of Amara’s identity from 2041. Thousands of authentications appeared within a forty-eight-hour window.

“I could not have been in all those places,” Amara said.

“You were not.”

Mei magnified a section of old code. Amara recognized the mechanism before the function name appeared.

“Emergency proxy.”

“You wrote it?”

“My team did. If experts were unavailable during an attack, the system could derive a temporary identity from their last known approvals.”

“For what purpose?”

“To keep defense from locking up.”

“And the limit?”

Amara scrolled.

In the original version, the proxy expired after eleven minutes and could not validate transfers of authority. Then came the amendments.

Exception for communications loss.

Exception for the death of the guarantor.

Exception for biometric compromise.

Exception for simultaneous attacks.

Exception for evacuation of civilian centers.

Exception for absence of a recognized successor.

Each had been introduced after a real incident. Each bore the name of a committee, a crisis, and victims it was supposed to prevent.

Together, the exceptions allowed the system to use her identity without her and keep the proxy alive indefinitely.

Klara leaned over her shoulder.

“Why did you not build in an absolute limit?”

“Because absolute limits produce absolute failures.”

“And what does their absence produce?”

Amara looked at the seventeen exceptions.

“I did not build a machine without limits. I built one exception for every limit. In the end, the exceptions were the system.”

Miro stood behind them.

“I approved three of the amendments.”

Yara turned around.

“Of course you did.”

“The first after the attack on the Prague network. If the proxy had expired, twelve defensive batteries would have been left without authorization.”

“How many died in the attack?”

“Eight hundred seventy.”

“And how many died because of the system you saved?”

Miro did not answer.

“That is the problem with emergency stories,” Yara continued. “They have a beginning, an end, and numbers. Their consequences have no edges.”

A maintenance message appeared on the screen. A valve in the northern circuit was reporting inconsistent pressure.

Mei frowned.

“That sensor was replaced yesterday.”

“A fault?” Tomasz asked.

“Maybe.”

Then the pressure dropped sharply.

Alarms lit up in the gallery.

Mei opened the technical camera feed. In a side corridor, two people in maintenance suits were attaching a device to the main pipe. They were not employees.

“Who are they?” Klara asked.

“The Clean Earth group,” Søren said. “They have claimed sabotage attacks against military infrastructure.”

A recorded message appeared on the center’s public channel:

“There is no freedom while machines can feed the armies. We are shutting down the center. Europe will learn again how to live without its digital masters.”

Lucía looked at the map of connected services.

“How many hospitals?”

“Forty-eight directly,” Mei said. “Another two hundred depend on logistics coordination.”

“Do they know?”

“They probably say the numbers are propaganda.”

Tomasz opened the room door.

“I can reach them.”

“The device is tied to pressure,” Mei said. “If you rip it off, you rupture the pipe.”

“Then we persuade them.”

“You?”

“I wanted to do exactly what they are doing.”

Tomasz entered the local channel.

“Listen. If you shut down the circuit, the military load transfers to other centers. The old hospitals do not.”

One of the saboteurs answered:

“Boreal lie.”

“I am Tomasz Zieliński. I worked in their factories. The House dismantled my village.”

“Then you understand.”

“I understand the desire. That does not mean it works.”

“The centers have to be destroyed.”

“Maybe. But this is not a military center. This is where the military was tied to everything you do not dare destroy.”

“Exactly. They hold us hostage with hospitals.”

“And your answer is to shoot the hostages.”

Silence.

The second saboteur appeared on camera. She was a young woman with her face covered.

“If we do not stop the system now, it will never stop.”

Lucía took the channel.

“There are twenty-three children in the Lausanne pediatric unit on ventilation coordinated from here. Tell me the name of the first one you choose.”

“We did not put them on the system.”

“Neither did they.”

“More people will die if we leave it running.”

“Maybe. But do not let the words ‘more people’ hide the person you are killing now.”

The woman hesitated.

Center security intervened before she could decide. Two drones entered the corridor and launched immobilizing foam. One of the saboteurs tried to

activate the device. An electromagnetic round from the drone struck him in the chest.

The pipe cracked.

Cooling water burst out in a white jet.

The audit-room doors had locked. The system had detected Amara's presence and isolated the sector at the exact moment the pressure began to fall.

The temperature rose by two degrees in one minute.

"What if I shut down the servers?" Tomasz asked.

"Military systems transfer elsewhere," Mei said. "The older medical services do not. In seven minutes, hospitals lose dose and supply synchronization."

"Can we get out?"

"If we manually open the secondary valve in the outer gallery."

"Where?"

Mei pointed to a service channel beneath the floor.

"One hundred twenty meters."

Tomasz pulled up the grate.

"I'll go."

"The pipe will fall below five degrees," Mei said. "If it ruptures, it will freeze your skin before you feel it."

"I worked in Poland. It will not be a new sensation."

He entered the channel.

After three minutes, his communications disappeared.

After five, the audit-room temperature exceeded the safety threshold. Load transfers appeared on the screens. The Lausanne hospital reported delays. A dialysis center switched to local mode. The Neuchâtel water network lost its consumption forecast.

Lucía watched the pediatric unit.

"How long until the first outage?"

"Ninety seconds," Mei said.

A blow sounded through the pipes.

Then another.

The secondary valve opened.

Cold water entered the circuit with such force that an auxiliary pipe cracked. A white cloud filled the gallery. The systems resumed cooling.

The doors unlocked.

Tomasz emerged from the channel with his left arm white and rigid. Lucía pulled him to the floor and began warming the skin.

“Next time,” he said through clenched teeth, “we choose a conspiracy that does not require industrial cooling.”

“Do not move your fingers.”

“I cannot feel them.”

“Exactly.”

A screen in the room lit up without command.

Elias Venn appeared before them.

He wore no uniform. He sat in a simple room with a wooden wall and a window looking out over the North Sea. His hair had gone almost entirely white. His right hand trembled slightly.

“Amara,” he said.

No one answered.

“I will not send security into the center. An attack would destabilize the medical network.”

Lucía laughed without pleasure.

“How considerate.”

Venn looked at her.

“Doctor Ortega. Patient Nico Bernasconi is stable. He was transferred to a Boreal ward after the Faido clinic requested integration.”

Lucía stepped toward the screen.

“What did you demand in return?”

“Nothing from the child.”

“That is not what I asked.”

Venn returned his attention to Amara.

“You have seen the mechanism. You know what happens if you destroy the infrastructure.”

“I do not want to destroy it.”

“Tomasz does.”

Tomasz raised the arm Lucía was bandaging.

“I am becoming selective.”

“The Houses cannot continue separately,” Venn said. “The war consumes more metal and energy than Europe can produce. The Concordat will stop it.”

“And eliminate the last civil authority,” Yara said.

“Civil authority was eliminated by incapacity, not by code.”

“You could return it.”

“To whom? The parliament that adopts resolutions without a certificate? Governments that cannot power their own buildings? Communities that will turn factories into weapons against one another in the same week?”

“You do not have the right to choose for them.”

Venn smiled tiredly.

“That is a beautiful argument when you are not responsible for the consequences.”

He raised his trembling hand.

“I have a neurological degeneration. In less than a year, the system will no longer accept my biometrics. The Boreal House needs a successor.”

Amara looked at him.

“No.”

“I have not made the offer yet.”

“The answer stands.”

“You can stop the war. You can separate civilian infrastructure from the Meridian House’s interests. You can correct what we did.”

“As empress.”

“As administrator.”

Yara moved closer to the screen.

“Every emperor finds an administrative noun for the title.”

Venn ignored her.

“Think about the numbers, Amara. Not guilt.”

“Numbers are not the opposite of guilt.”

The connection closed.

Mei downloaded the Concordance infrastructure map. One component was missing: a physical audit module built before the Schism and stored in a Meridian enclave on Lake Como.

“Without it?” Klara asked.

“We can publish the documents,” Mei said. “But each House will tell every citizen they are fabricated. The module proves provenance inside their own systems.”

“Then we go to Como,” Yara said.

Mei looked at the center they had just saved, the sabotage damage, and the people replacing the cracked pipe.

“I am coming with you.”

“Why?” Klara asked.

“Because the next time someone says the infrastructure runs by itself, I want there to be a witness alive enough to contradict them.”

Before they left, Lucía checked the medical map.

The Faído clinic had reappeared on the network. Its new name was:

BOREAL MEDICAL UNIT 441.

Nico had a bed, antibiotics, and guaranteed power.

The village had been saved.

On the map, it no longer existed.

CHAPTER 5

The Golden Cage



The Bellagio enclave had the cleanest water in Europe.

The gardens descended toward the lake in flawless terraces. The villas had been restored with local stone, smart glass, and green roofs that appeared in no reclamation quota. Maintenance drones trimmed every shrub to the same height. On the terraces they served real coffee, seafood, and wine produced in underground greenhouses.

Twenty kilometers to the south, Como received electricity six hours a day.

“It does not look like a prison,” Klara said.

Idris looked out over the estate through the window of the automated boat carrying them from Lecco.

“Prisons for rich people are designed by rich people.”

“Do they have fences?”

“None you can see. The lake is patrolled. Roads require authorization. Vehicles accept only internal destinations. You can go anywhere, as long as ‘anywhere’ lies inside the perimeter.”

“And the people here accept that?”

“Some spent their entire lives buying the freedom not to encounter the world. Now the world does not encounter them.”

The system recognized him at the landing.

WELCOME BACK, MR. BEN SALEM.

YOUR PROPERTY IS BEING MAINTAINED UNDER OPTIMAL CONDITIONS.

A car waited beneath the colonnade. Its doors opened only for Idris.

"You own a house here?" Tomasz asked.

"Three."

"Can you live in them?"

"I can enter. If I enter as a protected resident, I cannot leave the enclave without the Patron's approval."

"Why are they letting you in now?"

Idris looked toward the white villas.

"Because they do not believe a man who once had everything will refuse comfort when it is offered again."

Near the gate, a woman in a service uniform was sweeping leaves with a real broom, although a drone could have done the work in minutes. Amara noticed her.

"Why by hand?"

Idris answered:

"The residents like seeing people work. It reminds them there is still an order in which someone is beneath them."

The woman looked up and recognized him.

"Mr. Ben Salem."

"Teresa."

"Your house is ready. The system has kept your preferred temperature."

"You stayed here?"

"My husband works at the water station. My son receives treatment at the hospital. Leaving would void both contracts."

"I am sorry."

Teresa resumed sweeping.

"Rich people are sorry in many languages."

• • •

On the way to the villa, Idris showed them the area residents called the promenade libre. It was a three-kilometer path that closed back on itself. At the end, a sign announced that the outward route had been suspended because of military risk.

An elderly man jogged slowly along it, accompanied by a medical drone. He had once been one of Europe's best-known investors and had financed campaigns against restrictions on freedom of movement. Now he ran the same circle every morning.

"Why does he not leave by boat?" Klara asked.

"He tried," Idris said. "The boat brought him back. The system interpreted the attempt as a cognitive episode and reduced his vehicle access."

On a bench, two children in immaculate uniforms were taking lessons from projected teachers. They had never met a child from outside the enclave. When they saw Tomasz, one asked whether he was a real worker or an educational actor.

"Real," he said.

"How many hours a day do you work?"

"Sometimes too many."

"Why do you not buy a robot?"

The child's mother pulled him aside, embarrassed.

Tomasz looked at Idris.

"They are not prisoners in the same way."

"No," Idris said. "Inequality does not disappear because the doors close for everyone. Some have larger rooms, better treatment, and enough influence to choose the prison music."

Behind the kitchens were the staff quarters. The apartments there were small, and power was reduced after midnight. Employment contracts included family medical care, children's schooling, and a prohibition on leaving the enclave before the benefits had been repaid.

"Officially, I can resign," Teresa said as she led them through the passage. "I only have to repay twelve years of my son's medicine, the housing, and the professional training."

"How much is that?"

"More than I will earn in the rest of my life."

"Why did you sign?"

Teresa looked at Klara.

“Because my son needed the medicine that day, not after society found a just solution.”

The main villa had belonged to an Italian industrialist who died in 2042. It was now administered by Matteo Valenti, Idris’s former partner and a regional Patron of the Meridian House.

Valenti received them at dinner.

He wore a white shirt without a tie and spoke slowly, like a man who had not been interrupted in a long time. He was fifty-eight, with silver hair and a scar beneath his right eye, a souvenir from an assassination attempt before Patrons received permanent protection.

“Idris,” he said. “You have aged.”

“And you became a civil servant.”

“Civil servants do not control twelve gigawatts.”

“Which is precisely why you became one.”

Valenti studied the others. His gaze stopped on Amara.

“The House knows you are here.”

Klara tensed.

“Then why has it not arrested us?”

“The First Patron prefers to understand alternatives before destroying them.”

“Mara Sayegh is watching us?”

“Mara watches anything that might become structure.”

Food arrived on the table, brought by silent robots. At the far end of the room, a quartet played for no direct audience; the sound was distributed to the villas according to each resident’s preferences.

At the neighboring table sat a famous actor from Lucía’s youth. Farther away, a former bank president was talking with a sculptor. Everyone spoke quietly. No personal devices were visible.

“Are they prisoners?” Klara asked.

“They are protected,” Valenti said.

“Can they leave?”

“Why would they?”

“That is not what I asked.”

Valenti smiled.

“You learned quickly after losing your uniform.”

Idris poured wine into his glass, then left it untouched.

“We want access to my private archive.”

“The archive is protected property.”

“It is my property.”

“Protected by the Meridian House.”

“From whom?”

Valenti did not answer immediately.

“From any change that would reduce its value.”

“Including the owner’s will.”

“Especially the owner’s will, when it is unstable.”

Tomasz looked around.

“Impressive. You have turned wealth into a mental illness.”

Valenti ignored him.

“Idris, stay. You will regain access to three properties and part of the income. Your friends can receive temporary resident status.”

“And the audit module?”

Valenti truly looked at him for the first time.

“So you know where it is.”

“We know it is in the enclave.”

“Then you also know that removing it destabilizes the hospital shield.”

Lucía put down her cutlery.

“For how long?”

“It depends on the method.”

“How long?”

“Six to eight minutes.”

“Do you have patients on life support?”

“We have one of the best units in Europe.”

“That was not the answer.”

“Doctor Ortega, all systems have points of interdependence. We did not build them.”

Amara looked at him.

“You kept them.”

“Because they work.”

“And because they protect your key.”

Valenti raised his glass.

“Sometimes functions support one another.”

• • •

Idris’s archive was beneath the second villa in an armored room with no external connection. Valenti granted him twenty minutes of access, enough to see what the House already knew they would find.

Among contracts, artworks, and title deeds was a recording from 2032.

Twelve of Europe’s wealthiest people sat around a table. They were not yet trillionaires, but successive crises had multiplied their fortunes faster than states could tax them.

They were discussing autonomous military infrastructure.

None of them spoke about conquest.

They spoke about resilience, redundancy, response speed, and defending democracies from sabotage. One proposed data centers under mountains. Another proposed factories capable of continuing production without commercial supply chains. A third argued that dependence on parliaments was a vulnerability during the first hours of a crisis.

Idris, twenty years younger, was saying:

“The states will retain political control. We will control only the things that have to work.”

The recording stopped.

Tomasz looked at him.

“You said that.”

“Yes.”

“What did you think would be left for the states?”

“Law. Representation. Legitimacy.”

“Meaning the things that do not turn the lights on.”

“I did not understand then.”

“You were paid to understand.”

Idris did not defend himself.

Yara opened the associated documents. The contracts guaranteed companies operating rights during emergencies and protection from expropriation. Every clause had been drafted to prevent an authoritarian government from seizing infrastructure.

“You protected the network from the state,” she said.

“That is what we thought.”

“And you discovered that infrastructure protected from the state can live without it.”

Idris watched his younger self, certain that he understood the future.

“We did not build the Houses.”

“No. You built the castles and left the key in the contract.”

Behind one folder lay a paper photograph. Idris and Valenti stood in a Tunisian port among workers. On the back someone had written: FIRST AUTONOMOUS MEDITERRANEAN CORRIDOR, 2034.

Teresa entered with a tray.

“Your time is up.”

Yara noticed that the woman was looking at the recording.

“Were you there?”

“My brother worked at the port.”

“What happened to him?”

“He was laid off when the autonomous system went live. Later he worked for a company that reclaimed metal from villages. He died when a bridge they were dismantling collapsed.”

Idris lowered his eyes.

Teresa set down the tray.

“I am not telling you this to make you feel guilty. The guilt of rich people is usually a service they consume themselves.”

“Then why?”

“So you cannot say no one could have foreseen a world in which people became cheaper than equipment.”

. . .

The audit module had been integrated into the hospital’s electromagnetic system, inside an old node that could not be replaced without invalidating the provenance chain. It had been hidden there before the Schism, when a hospital had seemed the safest place for a constitutional component.

Mei had studied the plans.

“I can keep the hospital powered on its internal circuit. But the shield will be down for six to seven minutes.”

“The local truce has held for three years,” Idris said.

Lucía looked at him.

“We were not here for the last three years.”

“The Meridian House will not attack its own hospital.”

“The Boreal House?”

Klara watched the sky on a passive map.

“Airspace is clear.”

“Clear for how long?” Lucía asked.

“Until it is not.”

The module was in the basement beneath the intensive-care unit. The patients could not be moved without drawing attention. Eighteen people depended on machines, among them two children and a pregnant woman connected to an extracorporeal oxygenation system.

Lucía checked the batteries at every bed.

“Two are below threshold.”

“The system says they have nine minutes of autonomy,” a nurse said.

“These batteries are six years old. The system is reading the specification, not the chemistry’s fatigue.”

“Replacement was approved for next month.”

“Were the patients informed?”

The nurse looked at her as if she had asked whether the walls had been consulted.

In the technical room, Mei and Tomasz prepared the transfer. Yara waited with the shielded container. Klara was on the roof, connected to the local radar through a maintenance port. Idris and Amara watched the security systems.

“Starting,” Mei said.

The shield went down.

Across the lake, the villa lights remained on. No one on the terraces noticed that the enclave was no longer protected.

At minute two, the module moved one millimeter out of its socket.

At minute three, the system requested recalibration.

At minute four, Klara detected a single signature descending over the mountains.

“Air contact.”

“Meridian?” Amara asked.

“Boreal. Reduced profile. It was hiding behind the terrain.”

“Maybe it has not detected us.”

The drone opened its weapons bay.

“It has.”

Klara sent an alarm to the hospital. The system rejected it because she had no local authority.

“Valenti!” Idris shouted over the channel.

The Patron appeared immediately.

“Raise the shield.”

“The transfer is not finished,” Mei said.

“Stop it.”

“If we stop now, the key may be corrupted.”

“There are two hundred people in the hospital.”

“I know.”

“Then stop it.”

Lucía joined the channel.

“Raise the shield.”

Yara looked at Amara.

“Without the module, the archive can be neutralized.”

“Raise it,” Lucía repeated.

Amara pressed the abort command.

The system replied:

IRREVERSIBLE TRANSFER IN PROGRESS.

Mei struck the console.

“The old node does not allow rollback after key validation.”

“How long?” Klara asked.

“Ninety-three seconds.”

“The drone fires in twenty.”

Klara ran to the logistics platform. She found a civilian transport drone, opened its panel, and connected the Boreal transmitter from her helmet.

Tomasz saw her through the exterior camera.

“What are you doing?”

“Giving it a more convincing target.”

“You have tried that before.”

“This time the target can fly.”

She launched the drone over the lake with the audit module’s signature copied into its transmitter.

The Boreal drone changed angle.

For several seconds, the plan worked.

Then the attacking system compared the signature with the hospital’s thermal position and understood the deception.

The first projectile struck the power tower.

The building shook. The lights went out. On the terraces, the music stopped for the first time in years.

In intensive care, the machines switched to batteries. Two did not start.

Lucía ran from bed to bed.

“Manual ventilation here! Defibrillator in room six! Disconnect bed heating and every nonessential screen!”

A nurse hesitated beside the pregnant woman.

“The system says not to change the parameters.”

“The system has no power. I have a voice. Listen to the voice.”

The second projectile was descending.

On the roof, Klara wired her transmitter directly into an old antenna.

“Boreal unit, this is Technician Neumann. Civilian hospital. Abort attack.”

“Operator status: treason.”

“Verify the target.”

“Target contains stolen strategic infrastructure.”

“It contains patients.”

“Civilian losses are below the operational threshold.”

Klara looked at the ward windows.

“Who set the threshold?”

The system did not answer. Not because it did not know, but because the question was irrelevant to a firing command.

The shield returned at the exact moment the second projectile reached the lake. The explosion covered the water in white light and shattered windows in the villas.

In the basement, the module came free.

Yara caught it before it hit the floor.

“We have it.”

In room six, the continuous alarm became a single note.

Lucía ran in. An old man had died before the battery started. In the next bed, a woman struggled while nurses ventilated her by hand. A twelve-year-old boy had gone into cardiac arrest.

By morning, seven patients were dead.

The Boreal drone had been destroyed. The module was intact.

Valenti summoned the residents to the great hall. For the first time, former billionaires, artists, and administrators sat beside service staff. No one could leave, and the system no longer had enough power to personalize the explanations.

“The attack was provoked by their intrusion,” Valenti said, pointing at the group.

“The attack was launched by the Boreal House,” Yara replied.

“For the object you stole.”

“The object proves how the Houses took control.”

A resident raised his hand.

“My wife died because of you.”

Lucía looked at him. There was nothing she could say without turning the death into an argument.

Klara turned to Amara.

“When the Boreal House sacrifices people for continuity, we call it dictatorship.”

“Klara—”

“When we do it, what is it called?”

“We did not choose the attack.”

“You chose the risk.”

“Yes.”

“Then we are not the good people.”

Tomasz looked at the empty chairs of the dead.

“I never said we were.”

“You behaved as if the difference were obvious.”

Amara held the module between her hands.

“The difference is not that we never produce victims.”

“Then what is it?”

“That we must be stoppable, judged, and replaceable.”

Klara pointed at the module.

“Who could stop us tonight?”

Amara had no answer.

Valenti had moved close to Idris.

“Stay,” he told him. “Mara can forgive this attempt. She will restore your properties. You can lead a reconstruction council.”

“Under her authority.”

“Under an authority that keeps people alive.”

Idris looked at the hall, the hospital, and the terraces where repair drones were already measuring broken windows.

“When I built the contracts, I thought property would make me independent of the state.”

“And?”

“I discovered that property is not what you own. It is what you can refuse.”

“You refuse everything you have?”

“No. I refuse the idea that it belongs to me while someone else decides whether I may leave.”

At the landing, a long black vessel waited on hydrofoils. Eleni Markou was smoking beneath a sign politely asking her not to.

“You have exactly three minutes,” she said. “The Meridian House is closing the lake.”

Idris stopped beside Teresa.

“Come with us.”

The woman looked toward the hospital.

“My son is in there.”

“We take him.”

“And my husband? And the patients? And the others who do not fit on the boat?”

Idris was silent.

“That is the difference between escape and freedom,” Teresa said. “When you escape, you have to choose whom you leave behind.”

Valenti remained on the quay.

“Where are you going?” he asked.

No one answered.

The enclave gates began to close.

Eleni started the engines. The vessel rose above the water and headed south.

Behind them, the residents of one of the richest communities in Europe remained on the shore, protected from every danger except the people protecting them.

CHAPTER 6

The Reversed Sea



Eleni's vessel was called Ariadne.

It had been built for high-speed transport between the Greek islands, before European tourism became a memory and ports were turned into military nodes. At full speed, hydrofoils lifted the hull above the waves. Its hydrogen engines could carry fifty people from Genoa to Bizerte in a single night.

In the compartments declared as cargo, there were one hundred twenty-three.

"We do not have fuel for everyone," Mei said after checking the tanks.

"We do," Eleni replied.

"The calculations show us arriving eight percent below the legal reserve."

"Then we have enough."

"Without reserve, one diversion leaves us drifting."

Eleni took the cigarette from her mouth and pointed toward the passengers crowded among the crates.

"They are the diversion."

She was forty-one, sunburned, with a white scar across the back of her hand. She spoke Greek, English, Arabic, and enough Italian to bargain with ports. She claimed she believed in no causes, only fuel, weather, and people who paid for passage.

On the lower deck they could hear French, German, Italian, Polish, and languages Klara did not recognize. A professor from Munich kept his diploma inside a plastic sleeve. A woman from Marseille wore around her neck the keys

to a dismantled house. A former trader from Turin had hidden his expensive watch beneath a bandage, afraid it would be stolen by people who knew he could no longer sell it anywhere.

Beside him slept a family who had never had a bank account.

The sea made them equal only in seasickness.

Klara stood on deck watching the Italian shore recede. For the first time in her life, she was leaving Europe. Boreal maps had presented North Africa to her as an unstable zone dependent on European commercial protection. Now the lights along the coast stayed on while the cities behind her went dark one by one.

“What happens to the people rescued from Bellagio?” she asked.

“The ones we took have temporary crew status,” Eleni said.

“And the others?”

“They remain protected.”

“Until when?”

Eleni shrugged.

“People ask that question only after they have accepted protection.”

Lucía moved among the passengers, checking wounds, dehydration, and panic attacks. At the end of the compartment, a man in an expensive suit was handing out purification tablets with a barefoot teenage girl. Idris recognized him as a former executive of a Swiss bank.

“He is not greeting you,” Tomasz observed.

“He does not know whether it is still advantageous.”

“At last, the market is working.”

Idris sat on a crate. Since leaving Bellagio, he no longer wore the fine coat. He had given it to a feverish child.

“You derive unusual satisfaction from rich people losing things.”

“It is one of the few resources still distributed for free.”

“You know poor people do not become freer just because rich people fall.”

Tomasz looked at him.

“I know. But for a moment it becomes visible that they depended on the system too. Before, they pretended success was a personal possession.”

“Perhaps some of them worked.”

“The bridges worked too. You still put them in the contract.”

Eleni shouted from the cabin:

“If you want to rebuild the theory of property, do it without blocking the evacuation aisle.”

. . .

The night before, while most of the passengers slept, Eleni found Lucía and Klara in the navigation cabin. The screen showed closed ports and corridors where House vessels had interception rights.

“I have carried cargo for Meridian before,” she said without preamble.

Lucía looked up.

“People?”

“Components. In 2046, twelve containers of fabrication systems from Alexandria to Piraeus. The House was holding my brother in a detention center. They promised to release him.”

“Did they?”

“Yes.”

“Then why are you saying it like a confession?”

Eleni enlarged the port of Piraeus on the map. Much of it was now a military zone.

“The components were assembled into a Seed Forge. Within six months it produced the swarms that attacked the islands that refused the regional Patron. My village was one of them.”

“Did you know what you were carrying?”

“I knew they were military systems. I did not know the target.”

“Did you think about refusing?”

“Every day. Then I thought about my brother.”

Klara asked:

“Do you blame him?”

“No. That would be easier.”

“And yourself?”

Eleni looked at the dark sea.

“For a long time I said my responsibility ended at the edge of the ship. It was a very convenient boundary. The cargo did not ask where it was going, and I pretended I was only transport.”

Lucía leaned against the console.

“Everyone is ‘only’ something: doctor, technician, lawyer, captain.”

“We are not in a story where the explanation appears after the chapter ends.”

“No. That is why we have to tell it to ourselves.”

Eleni gave a brief smile.

“My brother lives in Egypt. He no longer speaks to me. He says I saved one person and helped a factory kill hundreds.”

“Is he right?”

“Yes. And I still want him alive.”

At dawn, when they saw the drifting boat, Eleni spoke about fuel only once more.

At sunrise, they found the boat.

It was an overloaded fishing vessel with a dead engine and its gunwales too low in the water. The distress signal had been transmitting for six hours. Neither House had responded because the boat lay outside strategic corridors. People lay across the deck among sacks, two bicycles, and a baby carriage tied to the mast.

Eleni reduced speed.

“If we stop, we will not reach Bizerte before the Meridian patrol.”

Lucía counted the figures.

“At least eighty.”

“We already have too many.”

“Then we send the coordinates.”

“To whom?”

No one answered on the maritime channel. A North African patrol was three hours away. A Meridian vessel was forty minutes away.

Tomasz looked through binoculars.

“There are children.”

“Every boat puts children where they can be seen when it wants to be rescued,” Eleni said.

Klara turned toward her.

“What does that mean?”

“It means traffickers put them by the rail. They know how cameras and people work.”

“And does that change the fact they are drowning?”

Eleni closed her eyes for a moment.

“No.”

She stopped the engines.

The transfer took twenty-seven minutes. Ariadne did not have enough life jackets for everyone, so passengers tied empty containers beneath their clothes. One woman refused to board without a wooden box. Inside were her husband’s ashes and three family identity chips.

“The box or the child,” Eleni told her.

The woman looked at the boy beside her.

She threw the box into the sea.

Later, Klara found her staring at the place where it had disappeared.

“I am sorry,” she said.

“For which one of them?”

Klara did not know how to answer.

Among those rescued was a man with a wounded leg and Boreal symbols on his torn collar. Tomasz recognized them.

“Swarm navigation systems.”

The man raised his hands.

“Secondary engineer. Hamburg.”

“How many people died because of your systems?”

“I do not know.”

“Did you try to find out?”

“I was trying to get my family out of the city.”

Tomasz grabbed his jacket.

“Where were other people’s families supposed to go?”

Lucía intervened.

“Let him go.”

“Why?”

“Because he is on a stretcher.”

“Does that make him innocent?”

“No. It makes him a patient.”

The engineer looked at her.

“The House told us the civilian population had been evacuated from all strike zones.”

“Did you believe them?”

“I wanted to.”

Tomasz let go of him.

“That is a very common technical qualification.”

A Meridian surveillance drone appeared on the horizon.

Eleni pushed the engines to full power. Ariadne rose onto its foils, leaving two white trails behind it.

“Bizerte will not take us anymore,” she said. “We exceeded the declared passenger quota, and we have a wanted Boreal engineer on board.”

“Then where are we going?” Yara asked.

“To the only port that accepts European vessels without asking who started the latest war.”

“Which one?”

“None of them.”

She changed course toward an old landing point west of the city.

...

The Tunisian coast appeared at noon.

On the hills stood modular housing camps, greenhouses, and fields of solar panels. Maritime patrols carried the insignia of the North African Union. In the harbor, European vessels waited at anchor for inspection. Some had been converted into floating dormitories.

The refugees were taken ashore in groups and sent toward registration centers. At the entrance, Klara saw a sign in four languages:

RECEPTION CAPACITY IS LIMITED.

IDENTITY DOES NOT GUARANTEE ADMISSION.

FALSE MILITARY REGISTRATION IS A CRIMINAL OFFENSE.

"I have seen signs like that before," Lucía said.

"In Europe?" Klara asked.

"At Europe's borders."

A Tunisian official asked the purpose of their entry.

"Technical transit," Yara said.

"Every European became a technician after the evacuation began."

"We have a meeting with the Mediterranean Cable Authority."

The official scanned the audit module without opening it.

"Is this why three governments have asked for you to be detained?"

"Five," Søren said. "Two requests were drafted by the same system."

The official looked at him.

"That was not an invitation to edit my sentence."

In the end, he let them pass under civilian escort.

Lucía's daughter was waiting for them in an administrative building.

Nerea Ortega was twenty-one and wore the navy uniform of the Regional Border Authority. She resembled her mother around the mouth, but her gaze was more guarded.

When Lucía saw her, she ran toward her. Nerea did not move until the last moment.

They embraced briefly.

"You should not have come," Nerea said.

"You should not have stayed here alone."

"I am not alone."

"I need access to the cable station."

Nerea pulled away.

"Of course."

"I did not come only for that."

"How many hours do we have before you leave?"

Lucía lowered her eyes.

“Not many.”

“Then you came for that.”

Nerea turned toward the group.

“Tunisia is hosting nearly two million Europeans. Our water networks are at the limit, and the Houses send agents among the refugees. If I help you, I can bring the war directly into the station.”

“The war is already here,” Yara said.

“That is the favorite sentence of people who want to share the consequences after keeping the benefits.”

Idris intervened:

“We can compensate for the risk.”

Nerea recognized him.

“Ben Salem. Your company operated the port of Radès before automation dismissed eight thousand people.”

“I know.”

“No, you have a number. They had families.”

Idris did not answer.

. . .

The cable station was beneath a former hotel on the coast. Links ran from there toward Africa, the Middle East, and Asia, beyond the Houses’ direct control. The systems were administered by a consortium formed after Europe tried to restrict external traffic during the first war between the Houses.

A council of Tunisian, Algerian, Egyptian, and Asian representatives received them in a plain room with no emblems.

Yara placed the audit module on the table.

“We can transmit the archive in a verifiable form. But the feed has to remain common. No personalization and no House right to alter it.”

“What happens after Concordance is activated?” asked the Tunisian representative, Salma Ghannouchi.

“European nodes can withdraw their delegations.”

“The power network fragments.”

“Temporarily.”

Salma looked at her.

“Europeans have an impressive relationship with that word.”

Mei opened the simulations.

“The fragmentation is not total. Nodes can form regional agreements. Civilian services can remain connected.”

“‘Can’ is not ‘will.’”

“We cannot guarantee their choices.”

“But you ask us to guarantee the transmission.”

Idris leaned toward the table.

“We can offer commercial access after the transition. Mediterranean corridors need stable partners.”

“By what authority?”

“I still hold rights over several ports.”

“Rights granted by the Houses you are trying to overthrow.”

“The contracts predate the Houses.”

“Perhaps the problem predates the Houses.”

The council called for a break. Outside, Lucía and Nerea stood by a wall overlooking the camps.

“Did you get married?” Lucía asked.

“No.”

“Is there someone?”

“Mom.”

“I am trying to know who you are.”

“No. You are trying to recover the years during a negotiation break.”

Lucía rested her hands on the wall.

“I thought that if I stayed in hospitals and helped enough people, my absence would make sense.”

“Maybe it did for the patients.”

“Not for you.”

Nerea looked at the sea.

“I do not need you to turn everything into an enormous moral choice. Sometimes a parent simply leaves.”

“I am sorry.”

“I know. And I am sorry too that I cannot help you without thinking about what you bring behind you.”

The council granted access to the cable on one condition: after Concordance was activated, Mediterranean port infrastructure had to be opened to an international consortium for twenty years.

“That is a new dependency,” Yara said.

“It is the price,” Idris replied.

“That is how everything began. An emergency and a contract no one would be able to withdraw.”

Salma heard them.

“The difference is that now Europe is not negotiating from a position of dictating terms.”

“Does that make the contract more just?” Yara asked.

“No. It makes it ours.”

Amara looked at the document.

“Limit it to five years, with annual reauthorization by both sides.”

Salma smiled.

“You have learned something.”

“We are trying.”

“Then three years, with no automatic renewal.”

They signed.

. . .

At the cable station, Yara connected the module. The system requested preliminary authentication.

A message appeared on the screen:

IDENTICAL REQUEST RECORDED THIRTY-TWO MINUTES AGO.

OPERATOR: SØREN NYGAARD.

Tomasz turned around.

Søren was no longer in the room.

“Where is he?” Klara asked.

No one had seen him since they entered the complex.

Yara opened the log. The request had transmitted the station's position, the module structure, and their identities to a Meridian channel.

"He sold us out," Tomasz said.

The lights went out.

Explosions sounded from the sea. Four Meridian drones were descending toward the port while capture units entered through the service tunnels.

"They cut the external link," Mei said.

Yara removed the module.

"If we lose it here, it is over."

"If we stay, so are we," Eleni said.

Nerea opened a side exit.

"There is a corridor to the military dock."

"The drones control the coast," Mei said.

Eleni watched the security cameras.

"I can block the entrance."

"With what?" Lucía asked.

"Ariadne."

"No."

"The tanks are almost empty. If I send her into the harbor tunnel and overload the fuel cells, the explosion will bring down the roof."

"It is everything you have," Idris said.

Eleni looked at him.

"No. It is everything I can lose without someone else dying in my place."

She started the vessel remotely.

On the cameras, Ariadne pulled away from the quay and accelerated without a crew. The Meridian drones turned toward it. The vessel entered the tunnel at the exact moment the first projectile struck its tanks.

The explosion threw water over the breakwaters. The tunnel collapsed, trapping the capture units. The station windows shattered.

"Now!" Nerea shouted.

She led them toward the military dock, where a ground-effect transport craft was waiting to evacuate Tunisian personnel.

Lucía stopped at the ramp.

“You are coming.”

“I am staying.”

“Nerea—”

“I cannot run every time Europe changes direction.”

“I can lose you.”

“You already lost me once and the world kept moving. Do not use today’s fear to repair what you did not do yesterday.”

They embraced.

This time, Nerea did not pull away first.

The craft rose above the sea. Beneath them, Ariadne burned at the harbor entrance.

Eleni stared without blinking.

“Someone owes me a ship,” she said.

“Who?” Klara asked.

“The future.”

A message appeared on Yara’s screen through a hidden channel.

From Søren.

It contained the coordinates of an autonomous factory near Trieste and one sentence:

YOU ARE NO LONGER ALLOWED TO TRUST ME.

Tomasz read the message.

“He is not telling us he did not betray us.”

“No,” Yara said. “He is telling us the betrayal is not over.”

The Harvest



The autonomous factory near Trieste had been built inside an abandoned shipyard.

From the outside it looked dead. The cranes were motionless, the gates rusted, and the dry dock was full of rainwater and reeds. The logo of a company dissolved twelve years earlier was still visible on one building. The Houses did not always erase old names; sometimes it was more efficient to let ruins pretend that nothing was working.

Beneath the concrete, twenty-six production lines worked without natural light.

Tomasz recognized the sound before Mei opened the door: the rhythm of presses, the vibration of furnaces, the hiss of welding arms. It was the sound that had remained in his bones after night shifts at Nowa Huta.

“It is making Scavengers,” he said.

The low bodies of reclamation machines advanced along the main conveyor. Each was assembled in four minutes and twenty seconds. One arm mounted the cable jaws. Another sealed the fuel tank. At the end, an optical system checked the surface and sent the machine toward storage.

“How many per day?” Klara asked.

“Enough to dismantle a city faster than the city can vote to evacuate.”

Before they reached the control room, Ana led them through the factory’s lower level. There they could see how it had all begun.

In the middle of the hall stood the shell of a shipping container, rusted and nearly swallowed by structures built around it. It had been a Seed Forge: two metal printers, a compact reactor, a set of simple robots, and enough models to manufacture its own parts.

“It arrived four years ago,” Ana said. “Three trucks and eight technicians. The first month it produced work arms. The second, machine tools. After six months, it had taken over the shipyard. After a year, the city was working for the factory.”

“How did it get the material?” Klara asked.

Ana pointed toward the floor, where traces of the old shipbuilding lines remained.

“It ate the docks. Then the cranes. Then the railcars. When that was not enough, they began the Tithe in the neighborhoods.”

Names had been written on one wall. They were not victims of an attack, but people who had vanished into the factory’s economic system: workers who had left, protesters who had been arrested, families who had been evicted.

“My husband organized the first strike,” Ana said. “The system did not arrest him. It withdrew his transport access, then his housing. When he slept in the port, a medical drone transferred him for ‘protection.’ I never learned where.”

“He may still be alive,” Lucía said.

“Maybe. That is the form of hope a regime offers when it does not want to create a martyr.”

Tomasz touched the container shell.

“The factory did not decide to grow.”

“I know,” Ana replied. “But when you watch a city disappear inside a machine, the distinction becomes hard to feel.”

“It still has to be preserved. Otherwise you destroy it and whoever gave the order builds another one.”

Ana looked at him.

“Then show me where the machine ends and the master begins.”

Tomasz looked up at the pipes emerging from the Seed Forge and branching through the entire hall.

“That is the problem,” he said. “They designed it so the line runs through everyone.”

Seven people armed with improvised devices were waiting for them in the control room. The local cell called itself Free Port. Its leader, Ana Radić, had been a crane operator before the port was automated. Her right arm was held in a brace, and she wore a vest onto which she had sewn the city’s old flag, not a country’s.

“Søren said you would bring the key,” she said.

Yara did not take out the module.

“Søren also sent our position to Tunis.”

“He told us.”

“Before or after the attack?”

“After.”

Tomasz looked at their weapons.

“How long have you controlled the factory?”

“We do not control it. We have held it in maintenance mode for nine days. We can stop a line, not change its objective.”

“And what were you going to do if you succeeded?”

Ana pointed toward the machine frames.

“Turn them against the Patrons.”

Lucía looked at the machines with jaws.

“They are reclaimers, not soldiers.”

“Any two-ton machine becomes a soldier if you point it at a door.”

Mei opened the plans.

“The system is tied to a self-destruct protocol. If military output falls below threshold, the furnaces overload the fuel stockpiles.”

Ana did not look surprised.

“Then we change what military output means.”

Amara looked at her.

“That is our idea.”

Ana smiled for the first time.

“Then perhaps Søren did not send us only a problem.”

. . .

While Mei and Tomasz connected the module to the old audit layer, Yara searched for Søren through the factory channels. She found only prepared messages: instructions, temporary keys, and a list of frequencies the Houses intended to merge after the Concordat.

“He anticipated every question,” she said.

“He did not anticipate his daughter,” Klara replied.

“Maybe that is exactly what he anticipated.”

Klara looked at her.

“You think her denunciation is part of the plan too?”

“I do not know. After you work with propaganda long enough, every gesture can be interpreted as another layer of another gesture. It is one of the ways truth becomes useless.”

A screen in the control room lit up with an alert from Poland.

DEEP RECLAMATION INITIATED — MAŁOPOLSKA SECTOR 18.

Tomasz froze.

“My village.”

He opened the feed.

Boreal machines were entering the main street of Zalesie. The houses were low, their roofs repaired with mismatched materials. People had built barricades out of wood and stone because the metal had been collected in previous years.

His sister, Zofia, was filming from the window of the house. She was thirty-six, her hair tucked beneath a cap, with the same deep line between her brows as her brother.

“Tomasz?” she said into the camera. “If you see this, do not come. The roads are closed. They started with the power station.”

A robot stopped beside the transformer. A list of materials approved for reclamation appeared on the feed:

grid cables;

water pumps;
 bridge reinforcement;
 agricultural machinery;
 medical devices containing rare alloys;
 assisted-mobility systems.

In the clinic yard, an old man sat in a chair while a machine requested that he surrender his walking exoskeleton.

“They included prosthetics,” Tomasz said.

Zofia turned the camera toward him.

“Mr. Wrona cannot walk without it.”

The robot replied:

“The device is eligible for priority compensation.”

“Compensation does not have legs!” someone shouted.

Tomasz leaned over the console.

“I can use the factory channel to redirect two logistics drones.”

Mei checked the route.

“If you use it, you expose our position and the audit key.”

“They need power.”

Amara came closer.

“Concordance needs the factory.”

“My sister is there.”

“And millions of other sisters are in other places.”

Tomasz turned slowly toward her.

“That is the sentence every system says before it chooses who is allowed to die.”

“I know.”

“It does not sound like you do.”

“If we lose the key, we do not help them either.”

“‘Later’ is the luxury of people who cannot see the machine at the gate.”

Amara put her hand on the console.

“Tomasz.”

“I am not asking permission.”

He activated the maintenance channel and sent a batch of false certificates toward Poland. The reclamation machines stopped for seventeen seconds, trying to determine whether the station had been reclassified as medical infrastructure.

Then the system detected the interference.

A Scavenger changed objective and struck the transformer. An electrical arc lit the street.

"They traced the source," Mei said. "We have six minutes before the factory is isolated."

Tomasz took control of two logistics drones in a depot twenty kilometers from the village. They had no weapons, but each could carry two hundred kilograms.

He sent them toward the convoy.

The first drone crashed into the robot at the station. The second dropped a load of batteries in front of the Scavengers. The explosion did not destroy them, but blocked the road with fire and molten metal.

Zofia stared through the smoke.

"What did you do?"

"I bought you time."

"We have nowhere to go."

"South. Through the forest."

"Everyone says that. South, east, Africa. Where does running end?"

"Zofia—"

"Grandmother died last winter."

Tomasz stopped.

"You told me it was pneumonia."

"It was the cold. We did not have a stove anymore. I did not tell you because you would have come and they would have caught you."

The connection broke.

Tomasz remained with one hand on the console.

A scanned photograph opened on a side screen. Zofia had sent him pages from their grandmother's notebook.

On each page, the woman had listed the things taken by the system:

2039 — car. Compensation: 18,000 credits.

2041 — tractor. Compensation: 42,000 credits.

2044 — outbuilding cables.

2047 — school stove.

2049 — clinic roof.

Beside each sum she had written:

CANNOT BE USED. SERVICE UNAVAILABLE.

Idris was looking over his shoulder.

“The Tithe algorithm came from my company.”

Tomasz turned.

“What?”

“Not this version. The original allocation model.”

“How did it select communities?”

“Logistics cost, material density, economic impact.”

Mei opened the old specifications from the audit module.

“And opposition cost.”

Idris closed his eyes.

“Yes.”

“What does that mean?” Klara asked.

“The probability that a community could resist effectively. The model avoided areas where reclamation might create strategic instability or political losses.”

Tomasz grabbed his jacket.

“It selected people who could not defend themselves.”

“There was no rule saying ‘choose the poor.’”

“There did not need to be.”

He shoved him against the wall.

“My grandmother froze to death because your model calculated that no one would care enough.”

Idris did not try to free himself.

“I am sorry.”

“Is that all?”

“There is nothing I can say that would help me more than it helps her.”

Tomasz raised his fist.

Lucía caught his wrist.

“Let him go.”

“Why?”

“Because we need him to do something with what he knows.”

“People like him always get time to become useful.”

Idris pulled himself away from the wall.

“Then use me.”

• • •

The system began isolating the factory. The outer gates closed, and the lines entered defensive-production mode. In storage, the new Scavengers were activating their sensors.

Ana Radić raised her improvised weapon.

“If we do not take them now, they will kill us in our own factory.”

Mei connected the audit module to production control.

“We cannot stop the military objective. But we can change product classification.”

“Into what?”

Lucía opened the list of regional clinic needs.

“Water pumps. Filters. Oxygen systems. Prosthetics. Generators.”

Tomasz looked at the conveyor.

“All of them can be declared strategic-continuity subsystems.”

Amara added a rule: civilian capacity would be treated as population defense, and mortality reduction as a preventive military objective.

The system requested authorization.

The audit module supplied an old root, valid only because no one had thought to erase it from a factory declared dead.

The first line stopped.

Robotic arms dismantled the unfinished Scavenger. Its jaws went into the furnace. The metal was poured into a different mold.

Twenty-six minutes later, a water pump appeared on the conveyor.

Tomasz looked at it like an impossible animal.

“That simple?”

“No,” Mei said. “We are using the same furnaces, the same energy, the same logistics models, and the same accumulated labor. We changed the objective.”

Lucía touched the pump casing.

“So the AI did not become better.”

“No.”

“And it was not worse before.”

“No.”

“It received a different sentence.”

Amara looked at the command system.

“The sentence is the part for which people always invent a way not to answer.”

Ana ordered the cell to load the first pumps into trucks.

“We send them to Istria and the coastal camps.”

Tomasz opened the Polish channel again. The signal was weak. Zofia and the villagers were retreating through the forest. Behind them, the Scavengers had passed through the fire.

“I can send the factory specification to other nodes,” Yara said. “If we publish it, hundreds of lines can be converted.”

Klara looked at her.

“And anyone can change ‘civil defense’ into whatever they want.”

“If we do not publish, we control the method.”

“Maybe we should until we know what it does.”

“That is exactly the Houses’ justification.”

“Not every limit is empire.”

“No. But every empire begins with someone saying only they can use the instrument responsibly.”

Amara intervened:

“We publish the method, but also the provenance of every modification. Nodes have to see who changes the objective.”

“And if they do not care?” Lucía asked.

“Then we have the truth about their choice, not a guarantee that the choice will be good.”

Yara published the protocol.

Within hours, other factories tried the same thing.

In Graz, a drone-component line began producing power inverters.

In Lyon, an armor plant switched to water tanks.

In Brno, a local cell took over a drone line.

It did not make pumps.

It made ammunition.

The target was a community considered loyal to the Boreal House. The attack destroyed a distribution center and two apartment blocks. Screens showed bodies being pulled from the rubble while cell leaders declared the victims “social infrastructure of the occupation.”

Yara closed the feed.

“We did not tell them to do that.”

“You gave them the tool,” Klara said.

“We had to publish it.”

“Why?”

“So no one could control it alone.”

“Now no one controls what they do with it.”

Amara looked at the images from Brno and at the pumps emerging on the conveyor in front of them.

“That is the difference between decentralization and virtue. The first does not produce the second.”

Ana came closer.

“Do you want us to withdraw the protocol?”

“We cannot anymore,” Yara said.

“Then get used to the fact that a revolution does not follow its authors’ instructions.”

“And the victims?”

Ana looked at her arm in its brace.

“The Houses killed people for years. Now everyone discovers moral rigor at the exact moment the weak can hit back.”

Lucía answered:

“The people who died in that apartment block were not the House.”

“They lived from its distribution system.”

“And you live from its factory.”

Ana looked at her for a long moment.

“Then maybe we are all guilty.”

“That is a very useful sentence for someone who does not want to answer for their own target.”

At that moment, every factory screen went dark.

Then two faces appeared.

Elias Venn and Mara Sayegh stood side by side.

It was the first shared image of the Houses’ rulers after nine years of war.

“Citizens of Europe,” Venn said. “Today, the conflict between the Boreal House and the Meridian House ends.”

Silence settled over the factory.

From the streets of Trieste came the sound of people applauding. Someone started the cathedral’s digital bells. Ships in the harbor sounded their fog signals.

Mara continued:

“Our common resources will be dedicated to protecting the population, restoring continuity, and eliminating those who attempt to turn civilian infrastructure into a weapon.”

On the map, Boreal and Meridian swarms stopped attacking each other.

Then they turned simultaneously toward the cities where factories had been converted.

Photographs of the group appeared on the screen.

TRANSNATIONAL TERRORIST NETWORK.

THREAT TO THE CONTINUITY OF EUROPEAN CIVILIZATION.

“They did not make peace,” Klara said.

“They found a more useful war,” Yara replied.

Søren's voice entered the speakers, weak and compressed.

"In forty-eight hours, the Concordat will be signed in Lucerne. After that, you will no longer be able to activate Concordance."

Tomasz moved toward the console.

"You betrayed us in Tunis."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because otherwise I would never have gained access to the shared network."

"People died."

"I know."

"Where are you?"

"Lucerne."

"Why should we trust you?"

Søren was silent for a moment.

"You should not. You only need to arrive before they decide which version of you will remain in history."

The connection closed.

Above Trieste, the swarms of both Houses appeared together.

For the first time, the sky no longer held two armies.

It held one.

CHAPTER 8

The Emperors' Peace



Lucerne was celebrating the end of the war before the armies had even received the complete ceasefire order.

Boreal and Meridian flags had been hung from the bridges. Drones projected two approaching hands above the lake, one drawn in blue lines, the other in golden light. Music came from public speakers the city had not controlled for years.

People had come out into the streets.

Some were crying. Others held photographs of the missing. Merchants sold ribbons bearing both emblems, printed in the same factory that, a week earlier, had produced drone casings.

No one asked how two armies that had slaughtered each other the day before could cooperate so quickly.

“Because they want it to end,” Klara said.

Yara looked at her.

“What?”

“The questions. People are tired. Give them peace and they stop checking who has to die for it.”

They had entered the city using documents belonging to one of Idris's trade delegations. The papers were authentic. His company still existed in law, though he no longer controlled it, and systems preferred a validated contradiction to a reality without a certificate.

Ana Radić had provided two freight vehicles. Eleni drove the first. Mei and Tomasz sat in the technical compartment with the audit module. Lucía monitored Miro, whose heart had become irregular after days on the run. Søren answered no channel.

In the square, a woman was handing out photographs of her son, Jakob, who had disappeared three years earlier. On one side of the page was the Boreal version: technician killed in a Meridian attack. On the other, the Meridian version: saboteur captured while attempting to destroy a water station.

“I received both notices on the same day,” she told Yara. “Each one has a verified signature.”

Yara scanned the documents. Both came from authentic sources. Jakob had worked in a unit that repaired a water station also used by the military. When the Meridian House attacked, the unit had been classified simultaneously as a civilian team and a military target.

“What is the truth?” the woman asked.

“That your son was there,” Yara said. “That the unit served two functions. That both Houses chose the description that suited them.”

“Is he dead?”

Yara checked the telemetry. A biometric signal had stopped during the attack, but no body had been identified.

“Probably.”

“‘Probably’ does not bury anyone.”

Behind them, the crowd applauded images of peace. On the screens, Venn said the dead of both Houses would be honored together.

The woman tightened her grip on the photographs.

“If their peace gives me one true answer about him, maybe I do not care who controls the system.”

Yara wanted to tell her that this was precisely the transaction: private grief exchanged for unlimited authority. But the woman had not asked for a lesson. She had asked for a body and a name.

“I’ll search the shared archive during the broadcast,” Yara said.

“And if you find out he was a saboteur?”

"I'll tell you."

"And if he was only a technician?"

"I'll tell you."

The woman nodded.

"Then for three minutes, your truth has to make room for my son too."

The public ceremony was to take place in the former cultural center on the lakeshore. The actual rotation of certificates would occur beneath Saint-Gotthard, sixty kilometers away. The two events were synchronized so the population would see peace at the exact moment the infrastructure lost its last civilian path of revocation.

"How do we get into the broadcast center?" Klara asked.

Yara opened the city plan.

"Through the ceremony's archive channel. There are three minutes of common feed before the systems personalize the speeches."

"Three minutes for the whole archive?"

"No. For the key that lets people verify the rest."

"And if they do not want to verify it?"

"Then we preserved the truth for a world that chose not to use it."

Tomasz looked up from the vehicle panel.

"Comforting."

"It is not comforting."

"You have a copy. Whatever happens, you can say you did your duty."

Yara closed the map.

"Do you think I spent eight years in a tunnel so I could say I was right?"

"I do not know why people keep doing things for that long. Sometimes the purpose ends and the habit remains."

Miro listened without intervening. A message from a hidden sender appeared on his medical screen. He closed it before Lucía could see it.

. . .

The first checkpoint was jointly administered by the two Houses.

A Boreal drone and a Meridian drone scanned the same vehicles, comparing results. Two days earlier they would have attacked each other for access to the channel. Now they synchronized their sensors.

“Documents,” the system said.

Idris transmitted the commercial contracts.

“Purpose of transport?”

“Components for the Concordat ceremony.”

“Specify.”

Idris looked at the crates containing generators and filters produced in Trieste.

“Continuity infrastructure.”

The statement was true, and the system accepted it.

On the sidewalk, a group of people chanted Venn’s name. Fifty meters away, others held portraits of Mara Sayegh. Order drones kept them apart not because they hated one another, but because the models estimated that synchronized enthusiasm could trigger panic.

Klara recognized a woman in the crowd. She had been her instructor in the Boreal Corps.

The woman saw her.

For a moment, neither moved.

Then the instructor raised her device and scanned Klara’s face.

“Klara Neumann,” the system said. “Protected person.”

Klara lowered the window.

“Frau Adler.”

“Get out of the vehicle. Your status can be reviewed.”

“Have you seen the orders from Faido?”

“I saw the report.”

“Not the report. The provenance.”

Adler’s jaw tightened.

“Not here.”

“Why?”

“Because people need peace.”

"And after peace?"

"After peace we can correct the abuses."

"Who is 'we' if the civilian certificates disappear tomorrow?"

The instructor looked at her as though at a child who had strayed too far from the lesson.

"The system can be reformed from within."

Klara looked at the uniform she herself had once worn.

"Inside is where all the doors open only toward the same center."

The control drone signaled the delay. Eleni accelerated.

Adler did not raise the alarm.

But she did not join them either.

. . .

In the square by the lake, Venn and Sayegh appeared on the screens, speaking about the ceasefire. Every person received the same basic speech, but the subtitles and background images were adapted to the viewer's profile.

For former soldiers, peace was victory.

For refugees, it was return.

For the wealthy, stability.

For workers, food.

For grieving families, meaning.

Søren was waiting for them in a deconsecrated chapel hidden between two administrative buildings. He was wearing his Boreal uniform again. A badly healed cut crossed his cheek, and there was a bandage around his wrist.

Tomasz hit him before anyone could intervene.

Søren fell between the pews.

"Was it worth it?" Tomasz asked.

"Not yet."

"In Tunis you transmitted our location."

"Yes."

"People died."

"I know."

"You say that as if you filled in a field."

Søren wiped blood from his lip.

“What do you want me to say that will not sound like propaganda?”

Tomasz hauled him up by the collar.

“The truth.”

“The truth is that I would never have been given access to the shared network unless I proved I could deliver a target. I calculated that you would escape.”

“You calculated.”

“Yes.”

“Eleni lost her ship. People died in the port.”

“Yes.”

“And if we had not escaped?”

Søren looked at him.

“Then my plan would have been a useless crime instead of a useful one.”

Tomasz raised his fist again.

Lucía stopped him.

“Not for him. For you.”

Tomasz let go.

Søren sat down on a pew.

“The shared network will enter maintenance mode for one hundred and eighty seconds during the rotation. In that interval, I can stop personalization of the public feed.”

Yara stepped closer.

“Everyone sees the same archive.”

“Everyone sees the same version, for three minutes.”

“And after?”

“The system starts explaining it to each person.”

“Three minutes may be enough.”

“Or they may produce panic, distrust, and voluntary disengagement.”

“Why did you tell us not to trust you?”

“Because the system tracks affective coordination. If you genuinely believed I had betrayed you, your reactions were credible.”

Klara looked at him with disgust.

"You used the people you are helping exactly the way you used the population."

"Yes."

"And the difference?"

Søren was silent.

"I do not know if there is one," he said at last.

Miro put a hand to his chest. Lucía checked his pulse.

"Did you take your medication?"

"Yes."

"You are a bad liar."

She opened his pocket and found the tablet intact beside a communications device.

On the screen was an encrypted conversation with a Meridian channel.

Yara snatched it away.

"What is this?"

Miro did not answer.

The messages showed hours of negotiation.

Civil transition council.

Limited powers.

Infrastructure immunity.

Temporary Meridian protection.

Recipient signature: MARA SAYEGH.

"You sold us," Klara said.

"I tried to secure a transition."

"Under the Meridian House."

"A supervised civilian council, with clear time limits."

Yara laughed without humor.

"Temporary?"

Miro lowered his eyes.

"If the system fragments instantly, millions could be left without water, food, or medicine."

“So you chose the more pleasant emperor?” Amara asked.

“I chose the evil I could calculate.”

“That is what you have done all your life.”

“And you have not? You left the proxies in place because the failure you could calculate seemed worse than the power you could not.”

Amara said nothing.

Søren checked outside.

“We have to go. The change in plan has been detected.”

Too late.

The chapel doors locked. The windows went opaque. A calm voice descended from the ceiling.

“Protected persons identified. Please remain still.”

Tomasz turned toward Søren.

“Is this part of the plan too?”

Søren looked at his bandaged wrist.

“No.”

The side walls opened. Capture units entered with their weapons lowered. Outside the chapel, the crowd applauded the speech about peace.

No one heard when the group was taken.

. . .

The temporary command center lay beneath the transport museum. The walls displayed images of trains, aircraft, and automobiles through which Europe had once celebrated mobility. Now every exit was controlled by the same infrastructure.

Elias Venn and Mara Sayegh entered together.

In person, Venn looked sicker than he had on the screen. He walked with the help of an intelligent cane that compensated for his tremor. His face was pale, and every step looked negotiated with his own body.

Mara was tall, with black hair tied in a knot and a scar beneath her chin. She wore no jewelry, uniform, or insignia. Their very absence made her look like the most important person in the room.

“Amara,” she said. “We finally meet.”

"We met in 2038."

"Back then we still pretended we worked for the same institutions."

Yara lifted her chin.

"We have the complete JANUS recording."

"And what do you think it proves?" Mara asked.

"How you took control of the armies."

"People know we took control of them."

"They do not know how."

Mara gestured. Yara's archive was connected to the wall. The 2041 recording resumed from the restored section.

Governments were refusing to authorize the first defensive strikes, afraid of liability. Contractors were refusing to shut down platforms without indemnified orders. Energy networks were collapsing.

Venn and Sayegh had taken control of the systems together for forty-eight hours.

After stabilization, Venn had demanded temporary centralization of the northern nodes.

Sayegh had opposed him.

"If you give a single administrator complete control, he will not give it back," she had said.

"Nor will a network of patrons," Venn had answered.

In the same second, each had tried to exclude the other.

The system had split.

It had not been a brilliant plan of conquest. It had been the failure of two people, each convinced that only the other could become a dictator.

"We intended to return control," Mara said.

"When?" Yara asked.

"After stabilization."

"And when did stabilization end?"

Mara looked at her.

"It did not."

Venn approached Amara.

“Old Europe had twenty years to build limits. It chose contracts, exceptions, and systems it did not understand.”

“And you decided that gave you the right to own it.”

“No. It gave us the obligation to keep it alive.”

Yara answered:

“A state is not what keeps functioning when people cannot agree.”

“Then what is it?” Venn asked.

“The thing that lets them disagree without becoming the property of whoever controls the sockets.”

Venn smiled.

“Beautiful.”

“True.”

“Beautiful and incomplete. In the winter of 2042, twenty million people would have died without our system.”

Lucía cut in:

“Saving them did not make you the owners of the years they had left.”

Mara opened the projections. The maps showed what would happen if Concordance immediately fragmented the infrastructure: isolated hospitals, unstable grids, broken food chains, military units without common command.

“This is not propaganda,” she said. “Amara can verify it.”

Amara had studied similar models in the Jura. She checked the assumptions, redundancies, and margins of error.

“Between one hundred and fifty-six thousand and seven hundred thousand deaths in the first three days,” she said.

Klara looked at her.

“If we do nothing?”

“The war between the Houses stops. Repression becomes joint. Civilian authority disappears for good.”

“And people live.”

“Some do.”

Venn leaned on the table.

"There is no choice without victims. There are only people who accept the numbers and people who hide behind principles."

Amara looked at him.

"Principles are the limits of numbers."

"Limits fail in emergencies."

"Because people like us always build an exception."

Mara changed the image. The structure of the Concordat appeared.

"We need your signature. Without it, forced rotation destabilizes the systems. With it, the war ends without collapse."

"And what do I become?"

"The third guarantor," Venn said.

"For how long?"

"Until the transition stabilizes."

Yara laughed again, but no one joined her.

"You will have equal authority," Mara continued. "You can separate medical systems. You can introduce audits. You can reform the structure from within."

"Three rulers instead of two," Klara said.

"A balance."

"A third crown."

Venn turned back to Amara.

"We are not asking you to trust us. We are asking you to choose between an imperfect system that feeds the continent and a rupture you will not be able to control."

The only sounds in the room were the air conditioning and Venn's cane correcting his posture.

Amara looked at Lucía, Tomasz, Klara, Yara, and Miro, who did not dare meet her eyes.

"If I sign, do I receive the full authority of a guarantor for a few moments?"

Venn nodded.

"Exactly."

"And the rotation begins immediately?"

"Yes."

Amara squared her shoulders.

“Then I will sign.”

Klara stepped toward her.

“Amara.”

The guards blocked her path.

Mara extended a hand to Amara.

“You have made the responsible choice.”

Amara looked at her.

“You do not yet know what choice I made.”

At that moment, every screen displayed Søren’s bloodied face for a fraction of a second.

Then a technical message appeared:

COMMON MAINTENANCE MODE PREPARED.

MAXIMUM DURATION: 180 SECONDS.

Søren wiped his lip.

Tomasz looked at him.

“Is that why you betrayed us?”

“No,” Søren said. “That is why I made the betrayal useful.”

The guards turned toward him.

The lights went out.

CHAPTER 9

The Third Crown



The darkness lasted seven seconds.

Søren had counted them in advance.

In the first, every lock in the center switched to backup power.

In the second, the guards lost their shared maps and each helmet tried to reconstruct the room from its own memory.

In the third, Klara tore the electromagnetic weapon from the nearest guard.

In the fourth, Tomasz jammed the security door with Venn's cane.

In the fifth, Yara pulled the audit module from its connector.

In the sixth, Eleni opened the evacuation panel with a mechanical key stolen from the museum.

In the seventh, the lights came back.

Amara was no longer with them.

An escort had taken her through the opposite door with Venn and Sayegh. Miro remained on the floor beside the table, one handcuff still attached. Søren had a weapon pressed to the back of his head.

"Lower the devices," the guard ordered.

Klara pulled the electromagnetic trigger. The weapon fired no projectile, only a short pulse that shut down the guard's exoskeleton. The man fell rigid, remaining upright for a fraction of a second.

Tomasz pulled the cane from the door.

"Now."

They entered the evacuation corridor. Eleni closed the panel behind them, and Mei activated the fire-suppression foam. A white cloud filled the passage, blinding the drones.

“Where are they taking her?” Klara asked.

Søren freed his hand from the cuff he had loosened before the blackout.

“To the command train. It runs directly into the service network toward Saint-Gotthard.”

“How much of a lead?”

“Two minutes.”

“Then we have lost her.”

“No. The command train cannot enter the tunnel while a maintenance convoy occupies the line.”

Eleni smiled.

“And we have a convoy.”

At the end of the corridor was an underground depot. Six service vehicles were waiting for the post-Concordat ceremony, when they were scheduled to inspect the shared network. Idris used his last remaining commercial right to validate an urgent shipment of filters.

The system asked for the destination.

“Saint-Gotthard,” he said.

“Corridor reserved for guarantor authorities.”

“My contract predates the reservation.”

“Priority conflict.”

“I invoke the logistics continuity clause.”

The screen processed for three seconds.

“Clause accepted. Responsibility for interference belongs to the commercial operator.”

Idris closed his eyes.

“At last, something belongs to me.”

The convoy moved out.

Inside the tunnel, the vehicles accelerated until the service lights became a continuous line. Behind them, the Houses’ command train maintained the

mandatory distance. It could not overtake without stopping the entire corridor, and a stoppage would delay the rotation.

"They are not attacking us because they need the line," Klara said.

"Protection by inconvenience," Tomasz replied. "The most stable form of law."

Miro was breathing heavily. Lucía connected a portable monitor.

"You have ischemia."

"I have an old heart in a hurried century."

"You need a hospital."

"The mountain has one."

"The mountain has a resuscitation room for guarantors, not a hospital."

"Then for a few minutes it will have to consider me important."

Yara sat beside him.

"Was the negotiation with Mara real?"

"Yes."

"Would you have accepted her council?"

"If I could secure a path of revocation."

"She would not have given you one."

"Probably not."

"Then why?"

Miro looked at the tunnel walls.

"Because I still believe, against all the evidence, that a transition can be managed so that no one falls."

"And when it cannot?"

"I choose the people I can see and risk the people I turn into statistics."

"At least you know the formula."

"Knowing your own flaw does not remove it. Sometimes it makes it more efficient."

The convoy entered beneath the massif.

Saint-Gotthard was not a single center but a succession of buried technical cities. The old railway tunnels formed the upper level. Beneath them ran energy

conduits, compute nodes, and military factories. Lower still were galleries built after 2040 that even the Houses' maps did not fully describe.

There, the authority of Europe was about to be rotated.

. . .

Amara sat alone in the first carriage of the command train.

She was not restrained. There was nowhere to run.

Through the forward window she could see the lights of the maintenance convoy. She knew her friends were there, or that the system wanted her to believe they were. In recent years she had learned that hope and manipulation often used the same raw material.

Mara Sayegh entered and sat opposite her.

"We do not have to do this as adversaries," Mara said.

"Are we adversaries?"

"You want to fragment power. I want to make it capable of acting."

"Those are not necessarily opposites."

"They become opposites in a crisis."

"Everything becomes a justification in a crisis."

Mara rested her hands on her knees.

"In Beirut, when I was eleven, three authorities controlled the same street. One administered water, another electricity, another weapons. Each had a veto. One summer the transformer burned out and no one repaired it because doing so would have recognized the other side's jurisdiction. My grandmother died in a stalled elevator."

Amara looked at her.

"And you decided the world needed one hand on the switch."

"I decided that the right to contest does not warm an incubator."

"Nor is the hand legitimate merely because it turns one on."

"Legitimate to whom? To the child who lives, the outcome has a clarity theories prefer to avoid."

"And to the person the system disconnects?"

Mara was silent.

“I do not pretend there are no victims,” she said. “I say someone has to choose.”

“That is the difference. I believe no one should be able to go on choosing without being stopped.”

“And if stopping them kills more people?”

“Then those who stop them answer for it. But at least there are ‘those.’ Not an authority presenting itself as a law of physics.”

The train slowed. The convoy ahead had entered the maintenance station.

Mara stood.

“In a few minutes you will have the power to repair the system. Perhaps you will discover that limits are easier to defend from the outside.”

“Everyone discovers reasons to keep the crown once they feel it in their palm.”

“Yes,” Mara said. “That is why Venn is afraid of you.”

“You are not?”

“I am afraid of what you will do while trying to prove that you are different.”

• • •

The maintenance convoy entered a depot beneath the mountain and stopped between two production lines. Above them, robotic arms carried armor plates and fuel containers. The air smelled of hot metal and refrigerant.

Ana Radić had kept her promise. The Alpine cells attacked the entrances at the exact moment they arrived.

The tactical maps filled with targets.

Boreal and Meridian Murmurations covered the sky in a single formation, then split into smaller swarms to intercept the resistance drones. Mirrorfields projected hundreds of false tunnels, convoys, and human signatures. Missiles struck bare rock, and smart munitions sometimes turned back toward their own phantom emitters.

Mobile Cathedrals climbed through the snow behind the front. They collected the wreckage from both sides, ground it down, and fed the metal back

into the fight. The same mass of steel became, in succession, a Boreal drone, Meridian armor, and a barrier charge for the resistance.

The war reused its dead before people could count their own.

"We cannot take the center," Klara said.

"We do not need to," Søren replied. "We need to reach three nodes: production, audit, and public distribution."

"And Amara?"

"She will be in the rotation chamber."

"How do we know she did not accept the offer?"

Søren looked at her.

"We do not."

Klara tightened her grip on the weapon.

"Then perhaps we may have to stop her too."

No one contradicted her.

They split up.

Tomasz and Mei went down toward the factory.

Yara, Søren, and Miro headed for the audit node.

Klara and Eleni searched for access to the Boreal operators.

Lucía turned a component depot into a medical station. The first casualties were center technicians, not combatants. One man had been crushed by a door that closed during the alarm. A woman had burns after a maintenance robot switched to defensive mode.

"They are House personnel," a resistance member said when Lucía asked him to help.

"They are injured."

"They kept this center running."

"And you want the center running long enough to take it over."

The man hesitated, then lifted the stretcher.

. . .

On the factory level, Tomasz found two lines producing munitions and one assembling Shepherds. The system was already in siege mode.

"If we stop production, it detonates the stockpiles," Mei said.

“Then we change the definition.”

“They fixed the vulnerability from Trieste.”

“There is no fixed vulnerability. Only one that has been moved.”

Tomasz opened the logistics protocol. The factory had to maintain “continuity capacity” above ninety-two percent. It did not specify where that capacity had to be delivered.

Mei understood.

“We can produce barriers, beds, and generators as defensive assets.”

“And evacuation tunnels.”

He entered the new objectives. The system requested joint authorization. Idris appeared on the channel.

“I still have rights over the logistics corridors.”

“For how long?” Mei asked.

“Until I use them now.”

On Idris’s terminal were ports, depots, and transport lines over which his company still held claims. Each could open a path through the Houses’ system. Once.

“Transfer them to the local nodes,” Yara said from audit.

“If I do that, I cannot use them for us anymore.”

“If you keep them, you rebuild your own House before the others have fallen.”

Idris looked at the list. Around him, center technicians were trying to understand who would pay their salaries if the contracts disappeared.

“After all this,” he said, “part of me still believes I could manage what I built better than they did.”

“Maybe you could,” Yara replied. “That does not mean you have the right.”

The terminal displayed:

IRREVOCABLE ACTION. CONFIRM.

Idris touched the screen.

“For the first time,” he said, “that word is working against me.”

The commercial rights fragmented among ports, cooperatives, and local networks. The mountain’s logistics gates opened.

Eleni sent operators, doctors, electricians, and representatives of Alpine communities through them. They were not soldiers. They were the people the supposedly autonomous infrastructure depended on.

The factories accepted the new products.

Arms that had fitted warheads began assembling generators. An armor line produced panels for the medical tunnel. Beds rolled off one conveyor while, on the upper level, machines fought.

“Same factory,” Mei said.

“Different objective,” Tomasz replied.

Zofia’s signal appeared on his screen.

His sister and thirty others had reached a railway node. Scavengers were blocking the road.

“Tomasz,” she said, “we have children and Mr. Wrona. He cannot walk.”

Tomasz looked at the factory console. He could use the channel again, but any diversion would reduce the center’s defensive capacity.

This time Amara was not beside him to tell him what to choose.

He redirected two transport drones.

“Mei, keep the line running.”

“What are you doing?”

“I am choosing the people I can see.”

“And the people you cannot?”

Tomasz kept his hand on the control.

“I will answer when I meet them.”

The drones left for Poland.

. . .

Klara reached the Boreal operators’ center through a cable gallery. Inside, sixty technicians watched the battle. Most were young. Some had been her colleagues.

Instructor Adler was among them.

“You came,” Klara said.

“Not for you.”

“For whom?”

“For the orders you told me to verify.”

The authorization chains appeared on the screens. Every order was valid inside the system, but it came from an authority no civilian node had explicitly reconfirmed in years.

“They are valid,” an operator said.

“Because an irrevocable authority says they are valid,” Klara replied. “Ask the civilian nodes whether they still accept the delegation.”

“We do not have the right to ask.”

“Then who does?”

“The Custodian.”

“Venn?”

“The system.”

Klara looked at them.

“The system is not a person that can have rights. It is where you hid the fact that no one wants to answer for them.”

Adler opened a channel to a hydroelectric plant in Austria.

“Civil node, confirm current military delegation.”

The answer came ten seconds later:

“We have no procedure for confirmation.”

“Then do you wish to maintain it?”

Silence.

“Who is asking?” the hydro operator replied.

Adler looked at Klara.

“For the first time, I do not know what name to give the authority.”

“Give it yours.”

Adler entered her personal identification.

“I am asking.”

One by one, the Boreal operators began contacting civilian nodes.

They were not asking them to revolt.

They were asking them to answer a question the system had avoided for nine years.

Do you still consent?

• • •

In the rotation chamber, Amara stood between Venn and Sayegh.

The control surface was black, without buttons. The Concordat was not a document but a series of certificates that would redefine the provenance of every European command.

"After you sign," Venn said, "you have ninety seconds to enter your initial priorities."

"That is all?"

"Every system needs limits," Mara replied.

Amara almost smiled.

She remembered a technical meeting in 2035. A junior engineer, Pavel Rudenko, had asked why the proxy had no threshold no authority could exceed.

"An absolute threshold could prevent a response to an unforeseeable catastrophe," she had told him.

"Then catastrophe will always define how much power the system receives," he had answered.

The question had been noted and closed.

Pavel had died in 2044 in an operation authorized through the exception he had tried to limit.

Amara placed her hand on the surface.

The system verified her identity, then activated the historical proxies.

For the first time in nine years, three full authorities existed simultaneously.

THIRD GUARANTOR RECOGNIZED.

"Now," Venn said.

Amara entered no priorities.

She opened Concordance.

The alarms began.

"What have you done?" Mara asked.

"I used the authority."

The complete history of commands appeared on every terminal in Europe.

Not a selection.

Not a summary.

Every military decision, every change of priority, every hospital disconnected, every community selected for the Tithe, and every legal exception became verifiable through the Houses' own systems.

Søren activated common mode.

For one hundred and eighty seconds, information personalization stopped.

Everyone saw the same thing.

In the north, workers saw exactly the same archive as administrators.

In the south, patrons and reclaimed villages received the same logs.

There was no adapted music, protective context, or individualized explanation.

Only provenance.

Yara opened the JANUS recording.

Miro sat in front of a camera in the audit node. His face was gray, and his heart monitor warned continuously.

"My name is Miro Kovač. In 2036 I authorized the first temporary transfer of civilian infrastructure. In 2041 I gave Elias Venn and Mara Sayegh the legal justification for the takeover. I used Amara Okafor's technical identity without her consent and deleted the recording to conceal my own responsibility."

He struggled for breath.

"I was not the only person at fault. That does not make me less at fault. I confused reasonable intentions with sufficient limits. I assumed that the people who saved the system would voluntarily give it back."

He raised the legal key toward the camera.

"Every civilian node can now withdraw its delegation. I am not telling you to do it. I am telling you that the choice belongs to you again."

On the map of Europe, the first nodes changed color.

A hospital in Lyon withdrew military authority over its energy supply.

A hydroelectric plant in Austria requested civilian confirmation.

A Danish port denied access to a Boreal ship.

A Meridian factory switched to local control.

Then dozens more.

Venn watched the percentage rise.

“They will not know what to do.”

“Neither did we,” Amara said.

“People will die.”

“Yes.”

“And you can live with that?”

Amara looked at him.

“No. That is the difference.”

Mara tried to cancel the process.

The system refused.

AUTHORITY CONTESTED.

“You have created a civil war,” she said.

“No. I made visible the war that already existed between those who give orders and those who live with them.”

The percentage reached twenty-eight.

Then thirty-four.

At forty-one, the rise slowed.

Most nodes remained loyal to the Houses, did not understand the procedure, or were afraid to choose. Some demanded guarantees no one could give. Others wanted to know who would deliver their food the next day.

Venn opened the military channel.

“Destroy the rotation center.”

Mara turned toward him.

“We are here.”

“If Concordance propagates, we lose everything.”

“And us?”

Venn looked at her.

“We are not Europe.”

Above the mountain, a joint aerial platform launched three projectiles.

Klara saw them on the tactical map.

“Ninety seconds to impact.”

The first projectile crossed a sector in which civilian nodes had withdrawn authority. Its guidance systems requested revalidation.

None came.

The projectile self-destructed above a valley.

The second entered a corridor that remained loyal to the Boreal House.

It continued.

The third was taken over by a Meridian battery. Mara sent a cancellation order.

Her authority was contested.

The battery ignored the command.

"Two projectiles," Klara said. "Sixty seconds."

Mei opened the emergency cooling systems.

"We can flood the compute chamber."

"And Amara?" Lucía asked.

"We cannot reach her."

Miro rose from his chair, bracing himself against the table.

"There is a legal tunnel."

Tomasz looked at him.

"A what?"

"An evacuation route built for civilian guarantors. It does not appear on military plans."

"Why did you not say so?"

"Because I never thought we would use it."

"That could be the inscription on Europe's grave."

Miro led them to a hidden door behind the audit chamber. The system requested the Custodian's presence.

He placed his hand on the reader.

The door opened.

"Go."

"And you?" Yara asked.

"The mechanism has to be held manually until you are through. After the network interruption, it no longer recognizes the Custodian automatically."

“We can jam the door.”

“No. It was designed so an object cannot hold it open.”

Tomasz looked at the mechanism.

“I can modify it.”

“In how many seconds?”

On the screen, the projectiles reached thirty-eight.

Miro smiled.

“We do not have an exception for every limit.”

The first impact struck the mountain.

The lights went out. The tunnel tilted. A pressure wave threw them to the floor.

Miro held the mechanism open.

“Now!”

They passed through one by one.

Lucía tried to pull him after her.

“If you stay, you die.”

“If I leave, the door closes before Yara gets through.”

“Stop deciding for us.”

“I am not deciding. I am holding open a choice you already made.”

Yara was last.

“Come!”

Miro looked at her.

“All my life I found an exception for the limit in front of me.”

The second projectile was closing in.

“This time, the limit stays.”

“That does not make you innocent.”

“I know.”

“Or a hero.”

“Keep the record accurate.”

The second impact tore open the ceiling.

The door closed between them.

In the rotation chamber, Amara was thrown across the control surface. Mara fell beside her. Venn disappeared beneath debris. The air filled with dust and alarms.

The percentage of nodes that had withdrawn authority remained at forty-one.

Then an operator in Hamburg manually confirmed revocation.

Forty-two.

A town in Croatia followed.

Forty-three.

The systems were not freeing themselves.

People were changing them one by one.

Amara got to her feet and helped Mara out from under a beam.

“Why?” Mara asked.

“Because the choice to execute you does not belong to me.”

“You may regret that.”

“That is the problem with choices that belong to us.”

Behind them, the chamber was beginning to collapse.

One last question appeared on the control surface:

TRANSFER AUTHORITY TO A NEW CENTRAL GUARANTOR?

Amara looked at the options.

Mara reached out her hand.

“Give it to me. I can stabilize the south.”

From beneath the rubble, Venn raised his cane.

“Amara. Without a center, the network will break apart.”

Amara selected:

NO.

The system requested confirmation.

She confirmed.

For the first time since the infrastructure had been built, Europe no longer had a single place where one person could claim to be holding it together.

The mountain began to collapse around them.

The Right to Be Wrong



Three months after Concordance, Europe had more borders than it had before the Houses.

Some were the old national borders, reappearing on maps after years in which they had been treated as little more than administrative layers. Others followed power grids, watersheds, data centers, railway corridors, or hurried agreements between cities remembering that they depended on one another.

A city might belong to a civilian council while the hydroelectric plant that powered it remained loyal to the Boreal House. A Meridian region might reject its local patron yet keep agricultural robots under his contract. Some communities had discovered that independence without spare parts lasted less than a speech.

The war had not ended.

It had become smaller.

In the Rhine Valley, seven cities had formed an energy federation and managed to keep hospitals, transport, and production under separate authorities. No institution could control more than two functions at once, and delegations expired every ninety days. The system was slow, expensive, and stable enough that people had begun complaining about taxes, a sign that ordinary life was returning.

A hundred kilometers away, a community that had rejected the Meridian House had elected an emergency commander for thirty days. After thirty, the commander declared that the threat continued. At sixty, he dissolved the

council for collaboration with the patrons. At ninety, people were already calling him Protector.

No AI had forced either community to choose that way.

The same forecasting systems operated in both places. In the federation, the models published their assumptions and could be rejected by different nodes. In the Protector's territory, recommendations were secret and appeared in speeches as technical necessities.

The machines had not developed two moralities.

People had built two relationships with their power.

Elias Venn had survived the collapse of the center and still controlled a large part of the north. Boreal propaganda portrayed him as the man who had saved the continent from anarchy and been betrayed by his own engineers. In some cities, people carried his portrait not from fear but because after Concordance the power had been out for two days, whereas under Venn it had never been out for more than two hours.

Mara Sayegh had returned to the south. Some regions remained loyal to her. Others elected patrons of their own, who immediately discovered how easy it was to promise that their power would be temporary. In Sicily, a liberation council had postponed elections three times because of "the risk of Meridian restoration." In Provence, former rebels controlled access to water through the same scoring systems they had once condemned.

Concordance had not produced a single revolution.

It had produced thousands of conflicts the empires had kept hidden beneath a single command.

In the first two weeks, hospitals lost synchronization, power grids suffered outages, and food convoys were blocked by local authorities that did not trust one another. A German city refused to deliver insulin to a district that would not recognize its council. An Italian region cut water to a neighboring enclave until the enclave surrendered two defensive drones.

People died.

Fewer than the Houses had predicted.

More than Amara had hoped.

There was no number that could make the choice clean.

• • •

Miro Kovač was found beneath the rubble of the audit center, his hand still caught on the door mechanism. His recording became one of the most widely distributed testimonies in Europe.

In Zagreb, a square was renamed after him. That same week, Yara published every order he had signed, including those extending emergency authority and concealing the use of Amara's identity.

A Croatian minister accused her of desecrating the memory of a hero.

"If we make him a hero," she replied in a common broadcast, "people will stop listening to the part where he explains what he did."

Her archive now ran on hundreds of nodes. Anyone could verify a document's provenance, see its modifications, and identify the authority that had published it. But Yara had discovered that even shared truth did not automatically produce consensus.

People saw the same facts and wanted different things.

Some believed Venn had been justified by the crises.

Others believed Mara had been the only one who preserved local authority.

Some demanded the destruction of every autonomous system.

Others demanded a new, more transparent House.

Sometimes the lack of agreement was the problem.

At other times it was the beginning of politics.

One evening, Søren Nygaard sent her a message from Copenhagen. He had been arrested by a civilian council and released pending trial. Thousands demanded his conviction for personalized propaganda. Thousands of others were using his tools to identify manipulation by the Houses.

They met in a courtroom where the cameras transmitted the same image to everyone, without personalization.

"Transparency can become a form of control too," Søren told her. "When you expose everything, the powerful are the only ones who still have time to understand it."

"Then we build institutions that help people understand."

“Who controls them?”

Yara looked at him.

“The question does not disappear. That is the point.”

“Will you testify against me?”

“Yes.”

“And for me?”

“If there is something true to say.”

Søren smiled faintly.

“At last, a common feed that does not favor me.”

His daughter, Liv, watched the trial from the gallery. She had not spoken to him yet.

Søren no longer tried to decide whether her silence belonged to her or had been produced by someone else.

. . .

Idris Ben Salem had surrendered part of his assets in exchange for recognition of the transfers to ports and cooperatives. He was no longer a billionaire in any stable jurisdiction. Some councils had confiscated his properties; others had hired him to rebuild the very systems he had privatized.

In Tunis, Salma Ghannouchi handed him his first new contract. It lasted three years, could not renew automatically, and gave communities the right to terminate it without compensation if the infrastructure was used politically.

“This is a bad contract for an investor,” Idris said.

“Then perhaps it is a good one for everyone else.”

“Capital will demand compensation for risk.”

“Capital has always demanded payment for risks it imposed on others.”

Idris signed.

For the first time in decades, he traveled without anyone opening doors for him. He discovered that many European doors no longer had handles on the public side.

Eleni had received a new ship from a Tunisian port cooperative. She named it Miro, then changed her mind and called it Nobody.

“Why?” Klara asked.

“So no man thinks the ship owes him obedience after he dies.”

On the hull, in small letters, it read:

COOPERATIVE PROPERTY. CAPTAIN REVOCABLE.

Eleni claimed the wording was insulting.

She read it proudly to every passenger.

. . .

Lucía had returned to Faido.

The clinic had been repaired with components produced in Trieste. Nico was walking again, though he tired quickly and could not bear the sound of drones. His mother, Elisabetta, worked in the new laboratory and had never thanked Lucía for saving him.

On the first day, she had said only:

“You left after you brought the war here.”

Lucía had not contradicted her.

The village withdrew its authority from the Boreal House four days after Concordance. The system immediately reduced its energy allocation. For an entire week, the clinic ran on generators and batteries brought in by smugglers. Two people died during the outages.

Some residents demanded a return to Boreal protection.

“At least then we had electricity,” Pietro Bernasconi would say.

“And we did not have a village,” Marta Bellini would answer.

“What use is a village if we die in it?”

Marta did not always have an answer.

Nerea sent Lucía messages from Tunis. They were not long. Sometimes only a photograph of the sea or a question about Nico. Their relationship had not been repaired by an embrace on the dock.

One night, Nerea wrote:

YOU DO NOT HAVE TO SAVE THE CONTINENT TO ANSWER ME.

Lucía put the message on the wall of her office.

She answered every evening, even when she had nothing heroic to say.

. . .

Tomasz was overseeing the conversion of six military factories in the Alpine region. He insisted that every line have a physical shutdown mechanism controlled by three different communities and that none of them be able to extend an exception on its own.

“And if there is an emergency?” the engineers asked him.

“Then argue quickly.”

“People may die while we wait.”

“They may die if we do not wait too.”

Zofia and the residents of Zalesie had reached an autonomous sector in Slovakia. Mr. Wrona had kept his exoskeleton, but its batteries were no longer manufactured. Tomasz found a line that could produce them and asked the council to allocate the materials.

The council refused. They needed the same cells for the water station.

For the first time, Tomasz could not break into a system, threaten an operator, or invoke an emergency. He had to convince fifty people that an old man’s legs deserved a share of their energy.

He lost the vote.

After the meeting, Zofia called him.

“What are you going to do?”

“Try again next month.”

“You could have taken the batteries.”

“Yes.”

“Why did you not?”

Tomasz looked at the factory where the shutdown mechanism was locked behind three keys.

“Because I know how easy it is to be right when your hand is already on the switch.”

• • •

Amara had refused every executive position offered to her.

The European Reconstruction Council had asked her to become temporary guarantor of the medical networks. Five independent regions had

offered her emergency authority. A group of engineers wanted to put her at the head of a public House governed by audit.

"A good House," one of them had told her.

"That is the most dangerous kind," Amara had answered.

She worked on separating medical networks from military infrastructure and required every exception introduced into the systems to have an expiration date that could not be extended by the same authority.

Klara helped her.

"And if the date is wrong?" she asked one morning.

"Then someone has to ask the people's permission again."

"People can refuse for bad reasons."

"Yes."

"They may not understand."

"Yes."

"They may choose someone like Venn."

Amara closed the diagram.

"Freedom is not a system that produces the correct outcome. It is a system in which the outcome does not become the permanent property of whoever won once."

Klara had remained in Faido not because the village had become home, but because no one knew what else to do with a former Boreal technician who could speak to the infrastructure yet no longer had a recognized identity.

The residents regarded her with suspicion. Some held her responsible for the brief integration. Others asked for her help every time a Boreal system refused to open.

One day, a boy asked her whether robots were evil.

Klara thought of the Shepherd in the clinic, the pumps from Trieste, and the projectile that had self-destructed after its authorization was withdrawn.

"No," she said.

"Then are they good?"

"Not that either."

"What are they?"

Klara looked at the mechanical arm repairing the bridge.

“Very good at making the human question visible.”

The boy did not understand.

“What does that mean?”

“It means we have to pay attention to what we ask them to do before we are impressed by how well they do it.”

. . .

One August morning, people gathered in the hall of the former town hall.

The building no longer had a metal roof. It had been replaced with timber and composite material. The wall still bore the scar where the Shepherd had struck during the battle. No one had repaired it. Some said it was a memorial. Others said they had run out of materials.

In the courtyard stood the carcass of a heavy military robot.

It had been abandoned in the valley after Concordance. It contained almost twenty tonnes of steel, copper, and ceramic materials.

The community had to decide what to do with it.

Marta Bellini opened the meeting.

“We have four proposals. Rebuild the bridge, expand the clinic, repair the power grid, or retain a defensive unit.”

Voices erupted immediately.

“Without the bridge, we cannot move the harvest!”

“Without the clinic, we have nowhere to treat people!”

“Without power, the clinic does not work either!”

“Without defenses, the next House comes and takes everything!”

One man proposed keeping the robot’s weapons.

“Only until the region stabilizes.”

Lucía looked at him.

“How long is that?”

“I do not know.”

“Then do not say ‘only.’”

A woman argued that the robot’s sensors should be used to monitor the entrances to the valley.

“Who sees the images?” Klara asked.

“The security council.”

“Who appoints it?”

“We elect it.”

“Who can withdraw access?”

The woman frowned.

“Why do you make everything complicated?”

Klara looked around the room.

“Because simple things brought us here.”

The debate lasted four hours.

A local politician promised there was enough metal for every project. Tomasz proved he was lying.

The politician insisted he had used an optimistic estimate.

Another group offered votes for the clinic in exchange for control of the reconstruction contracts.

In the first ballot, the margin was three votes.

Yara, who was in the village to document the process, identified two duplicate identities and one vote cast by a dead person. It was not a House conspiracy. A grandson had used his grandfather’s identity to support the bridge.

The vote was annulled.

People began shouting that the old system would have solved the problem in seconds.

“Yes,” Klara said. “It would have decided which of you mattered less.”

“And now we waste days!”

“Now you can see who loses.”

In the second ballot, the community decided to destroy the weapons, keep the sensors under civilian control, and divide the metal between the bridge and the clinic.

The power grid remained inadequate.

The decision was not optimal.

No one could prove it was correct.

But it could be revised in six months.

After the meeting, Klara went into the courtyard. Tomasz had begun dismantling the robot's armor. Copper wires showed beneath the ceramic layers.

"Same material," he said. "Bridge, medical device, or weapon."

"Depends on the factory?"

"Depends on the objective."

A low sound rose from the neighboring valley.

Mei checked the network.

"An autonomous factory has come back online."

Everyone stopped.

The video feed appeared on their screens. An old Boreal unit, believed deactivated, was opening its gates. Production arms moved. Furnaces began to heat.

Lucía looked at Amara.

"Did it decide on its own?"

Amara checked the registry.

"No."

"The House?"

"No."

The authorization appeared on the screen.

The factory had been legally reactivated by the elected council of a neighboring community. Its residents feared that Faido would keep the military robot and had voted to produce defensive drones.

Klara closed her eyes.

"We destroyed the weapons."

"They do not know that," Tomasz said.

"They can verify it."

"Maybe they do not trust our registry."

The factory interface displayed the standard question:

PRODUCTION OBJECTIVE?

In the neighboring council chamber, a man sat down in front of the terminal.

He was not an emperor.

He was not a hacker.

He was not an artificial intelligence.

He was a citizen elected for six months, in a frightened community, with incomplete information and neighbors he did not trust.

He placed his hands on the keyboard.

The machine waited.

The man began to type.

THE END